SRINIVASSA SINAI DEMPO COLLEGE (AUTONOMOUS), GOA

Dempo AI Business School

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AI Applications in (New Age) HR

A Practical Studio Course — Research, Select, Implement & Build

Choose a field · evaluate real tools · implement on dummy data · build an AI prototype

COURSE PACK

Facilitator Notes · Student Handouts · Studio & Demo Briefs · Toolkit · 3 Demo Milestones

Two-Year PGDM · Second Year · HRM Specialization Elective

30-Hour Studio Course · Six Modules · Thirty One-Hour Sessions

Part of the Dempo AI² theme — Artificial Intelligence, Analytics & Innovation

Programme designed and authored by

Praveen Dalal

About This Course & How to Use This Pack

AI Applications in (New Age) HR is a 30-hour, deliberately practical studio course for second-year PGDM students specialising in HRM at Srinivassa Sinai Dempo College (Autonomous), Goa, offered through the Dempo AI Business School and designed and authored by Praveen Dalal. It sits within the institute's AI² theme — Artificial Intelligence, Analytics and Innovation — and prepares students to make and execute real HR-technology decisions.

The course follows the full life of an HR-tech decision. Students research the SaaS tools available in the market, learn to gather an organisation's needs and turn them into requirements, evaluate and select a tool against those needs, implement one tool end-to-end on dummy data, and finally build their own AI-based HR tool as a capstone — using today's no-code and AI builders. It is hands-on throughout, driven by student work, demos and mentor guidance rather than lectures.

Each student (or team) chooses one field at the start and carries it through the whole course: recruitment, performance management, HRMS, employee engagement, surveys, or payroll. Every studio, demo and the capstone is done in that chosen field, so students go deep rather than wide and graduate with a portfolio piece in an area they care about.

How this course differs from New Age HR: the New Age HR elective is a strategic, conceptual course about people leadership — deciding what to do and why (people strategy, analytics, talent, culture, the future of work, and where AI is taking the profession). AI Applications in (New Age) HR is its hands-on counterpart — deciding how to do it with technology: researching the market, gathering needs, selecting, implementing on dummy data, and building tools. The two are complementary, not overlapping. Where they touch the same idea (for example AI fundamentals, change management, or responsible AI), this course deliberately treats it at the practical, tool level and points to New Age HR for the strategic and conceptual depth, so neither course repeats the other.

There are three demo milestones that anchor the course: Demo 1 (the tool landscape and a recommendation, after Module 3), Demo 2 (an end-to-end implementation on dummy data, after Module 4), and the Capstone Demo Days (the AI prototype, in Module 6). The course evaluator acts as a mentor and panel throughout — reviewing work in studios, giving feedback at demos, and assessing the milestones — and peers evaluate each other with shared scorecards.

How the sessions are built: teaching sessions carry facilitator notes plus a printable student handout (key concepts explained in plain words with examples, a framework, often a reference table, practical work, thinking questions and short readings). Studio, demo and mentor-clinic sessions instead carry a brief — the activity, numbered steps, the deliverable, tips and the evaluator's focus. A Course Toolkit of reusable templates and rubrics, and a practical, demo-led Assessment model, follow the sessions.

A note on tools and data: students work entirely on dummy (never real) data, and may use tool free-tiers, trials or no-code stand-ins where full access isn't available. The specific tools named in this pack are current, real examples as a starting point for research — the HR-tech and AI market moves quickly, so students should always verify the latest options, pricing and features themselves.

Contents

Module 1 · Foundations: SaaS, AI & the HR Tech Landscape

What the HR tech stack is, how SaaS and AI actually work, and the six fields you can choose from.

Hour 1 Course Launch & the Modern HR Tech Stack

AT A GLANCE *15 min course model & teams · 25 min HR tech stack · 15 min field preview · 5 min set-up*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand how this studio course runs — teams, the chosen-field spine, deliverables, demos and the mentor model.
- Describe the modern HR technology stack and where SaaS and AI sit within it.
- Begin thinking about which HR field each student will carry through the course.

TEACHING NOTES

Open by setting expectations clearly, because this course is unlike a lecture course. It is a hands-on studio in which students learn by researching real software, gathering real-style requirements, selecting and implementing a tool on dummy data, and finally building an AI-based HR tool of their own. The course evaluator acts as a mentor and 'client' throughout — running clinics, giving feedback at demos, and judging the capstone — rather than simply marking exams. Explain the rhythm: teaching sessions build method, studio sessions are working labs, and there are three demo milestones (a tool recommendation, an end-to-end implementation, and the AI-prototype capstone).

Introduce the single most important design choice: each student (working in a small team) chooses one HR field early and carries it through every stage of the course — researching tools in that field, gathering needs for it, selecting and implementing a tool, and building an AI prototype for it. The six fields on offer are recruitment, performance management, HRMS / core HR, employee engagement, surveys, and payroll. Choosing a field gives the course a spine and lets students go deep rather than wide.

Teach the modern HR technology stack so students have a map. At the base sits the core HR system (HRMS/HRIS) — the system of record for people data. Around it sit specialist 'best-of-breed' tools for each function: an applicant-tracking system for recruitment, a performance/OKR tool, an engagement and survey platform, a payroll engine, a learning system. Above these sit an experience layer (what employees and managers actually use), an analytics layer, and — increasingly — an AI layer woven through all of them. Integrations and APIs connect the pieces so data flows.

Make the manager's framing explicit: tomorrow's HR and general managers will constantly face the questions 'what tool should we use, how do we choose it, how do we roll it out, and where can AI help?' This course builds exactly those decision and delivery skills. Close by forming teams and previewing the field choice they will lock in two sessions from now (after seeing the landscape).

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 1 · Course Launch & the Modern HR Tech Stack

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

HR tech stack — The connected set of systems that run HR — core HR, specialist tools, experience, analytics and AI layers.

In plain words: All the software an HR team uses, stacked from the master employee database up to the apps people touch and the AI woven through.

Example: A core HRMS holding employee records, plus a separate recruitment tool and payroll engine *that feed data to it.*

System of record — The single authoritative source of employee data the rest of the stack relies on.

In plain words: The one place that holds the 'truth' about who works here, which everything else trusts.

Example: The HRMS says an employee's department and grade; the payroll and performance tools read it from there.

Best-of-breed vs suite — Using specialist tools for each function vs one all-in-one platform.

In plain words: Pick the best tool for each job (more specialised, more to integrate) or one platform that does everything (simpler, less deep).

Example: A best-of-breed stack pairs a specialist ATS with a separate engagement tool; a suite like a full HRMS does both in one.

Studio / mentor model — Learning by building, with the evaluator coaching and judging demos rather than only setting exams.

In plain words: You work on a real-style project and get feedback from a mentor-evaluator at each milestone, like a client and consultant.

Example: At Demo 1 the evaluator challenges your tool recommendation as a sceptical client would.

FRAMEWORK

The course spine: choose a field → gather needs → research & evaluate tools → select → implement on dummy data → build an AI prototype → demo. Every module advances your one chosen field.

PRACTICAL WORK

1. In your team, list every piece of software your college or a workplace you know uses to manage people; place each on the HR tech stack map.
2. Write one sentence on why a 'system of record' matters when several tools hold overlapping employee data.
3. Shortlist the two HR fields your team is most drawn to, with one reason each, ready to commit in Session 4.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. When would an organisation prefer one all-in-one suite over several best-of-breed tools — and when the reverse?
2. What goes wrong when tools in the stack don't talk to each other (no integration)?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- Josh Bersin, research on the HR technology stack and 'systemic HR' (joshbersin.com).
- A current HR-tech market overview (e.g., a recent 'state of HR technology' report) for context on the landscape.

Hour 2 Understanding SaaS for Managers

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 30 min teaching · 15 min practical · 5 min discussion*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Explain what SaaS is and how it differs from traditional installed software.
- Describe the SaaS features that matter when choosing an HR tool: integrations, security, data, pricing, lock-in.
- Read a SaaS vendor's claims critically.

TEACHING NOTES

Define SaaS plainly: Software as a Service is software you access over the internet on a subscription, where the vendor hosts it, runs it, secures it and updates it — you simply log in. Contrast it with the old model of buying software and installing it on your own servers. Almost every modern HR tool is SaaS, so understanding the model is foundational to everything that follows.

Walk through the SaaS characteristics that matter to an HR buyer. Multi-tenancy: many customers share one continuously-updated platform, so you always have the latest version but less control over change. Subscription pricing: you pay per user (or tier) per month, turning a big upfront cost into an ongoing one. Integrations and APIs: how the tool connects to your other systems so data flows — often the make-or-break issue. Security and data: where your employee data is stored (data residency), how it is protected, certifications (e.g., ISO 27001, SOC 2), and compliance with privacy law. Service levels (SLAs): uptime and support promises.

Stress vendor lock-in and exit, which beginners overlook. Because the vendor holds your data and configuration, switching tools later can be hard and costly; before buying, ask how you would get your data out and what migrating away would involve. This is a key risk to weigh in selection (a later session).

Teach critical reading of vendor claims. Every SaaS data sheet promises to be 'powerful, intuitive, AI-driven and fully compliant' — the words look identical across competitors. Managers must look past marketing to substance: ask for evidence, references, a trial, and specifics. End with a practical comparing two real HR SaaS products' marketing pages and separating claim from substance.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 2 · Understanding SaaS for Managers

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

SaaS — Software accessed over the internet on subscription, hosted, run, secured and updated by the vendor.

In plain words: You rent software in the cloud and just log in; the vendor handles servers, security and updates.

Example: An HR team uses a payroll tool entirely through a browser, paying per employee per month.

Integration / API — The means by which a tool exchanges data automatically with other systems.

In plain words: The 'plumbing' that lets two tools share data without re-typing it.

Example: New hires added in the HRMS automatically appear in the payroll tool via an integration.

Data residency & security — Where data is stored and how it is protected, including certifications and privacy compliance.

In plain words: Which country your employee data sits in and how safe it is — a legal and trust issue.

Example: *A vendor storing Indian employee data must meet the DPDP Act's requirements.*

Vendor lock-in — Difficulty and cost of switching away from a tool once adopted.

In plain words: How trapped you are once your data and setup live inside one vendor's system.

Example: *A platform that won't easily export your data makes leaving expensive — ask about exit before you buy.*

FRAMEWORK

The SaaS lens for buyers: Hosting & updates · Pricing model · Integrations/APIs · Security & data residency · SLAs & support · Lock-in & exit. Run any tool through these six.

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Take two real HR SaaS products in your field and list, from their websites, their pricing model, claimed integrations, and any security certifications.
2. Write three pointed questions you would ask a vendor about data security and exit before buying.
3. Translate three marketing phrases from a vendor page into the concrete evidence you would demand to verify them.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why is 'we can't easily get our data out' a serious risk, even if the tool is excellent today?
2. Subscription pricing spreads cost over time — when is that an advantage and when a hidden trap?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- A plain-English 'what is SaaS' primer from a reputable cloud provider's documentation.
- India DPDP Act overview and the EU GDPR summary — the data rules behind 'security & residency'.

Hour 3 AI Inside HR Tools — Recognising and Judging It

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 30 min teaching · 15 min practical · 5 min discussion*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Recognise the forms AI takes inside HR SaaS products and what each really does.
- Judge a vendor's 'AI-powered' claim and tell a genuine AI feature from a label.
- Apply the buy-vs-build-vs-augment choice when AI is involved.

TEACHING NOTES

This session is deliberately about AI as it appears inside the software students will research, select and build — not about AI as a force reshaping the workforce. (The strategic, workforce-level view of AI and agentic AI in HR — how it redraws jobs, skills and the organisation — is the territory of the New Age HR course; here the lens is firmly the tool.) Open with just enough vocabulary to read a product page: AI broadly means software doing tasks that need intelligence; within tools you'll mainly meet machine learning (a tool that scores or predicts from data, e.g., a flight-risk flag), generative AI (a tool that drafts or summarises, e.g., writes a job ad or summarises survey comments), and agentic features (a tool that takes multi-step actions toward a goal, e.g., sources, screens and schedules). Students need these only to know what a vendor is actually claiming.

Spend the core of the session on judging AI claims, because almost every HR SaaS product now markets itself as 'AI-powered' and the word means very little by itself. Teach the distinction between an AI feature bolted onto a conventional tool and an AI-native tool built around it, and between a real, working capability and a roadmap promise. Equip students with the questions that expose substance: what exactly does the AI do, on what data, how accurate is it, can a human override it, and was it tested for bias? This connects directly to the research and evaluation skills in Module 3 — here AI becomes one more claim to verify rather than to take on trust.

Map where AI realistically shows up across the six fields so students can spot it in their own field's tools: resume screening and interview scheduling in recruitment; drafting and review-summarising in performance; query chatbots and anomaly checks in HRMS and payroll; and sentiment/theme analysis in engagement and surveys. The pattern to recognise: tool AI is strongest at volume, drafting, summarising and pattern-spotting, and weakest — and riskiest — when trusted to make consequential calls about people on its own.

Close by introducing the buy-vs-build-vs-augment choice that frames the rest of the course, now with an AI twist: buy a tool whose AI is proven, build a small AI tool of your own (Module 5), or augment an existing system with an AI layer. Most organisations do all three. End with a practical in which teams find the AI claims on two real tools in their field and turn each into a question they would test.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 3 · AI Inside HR Tools — Recognising and Judging It

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

AI feature vs AI-native tool — AI added onto a conventional product vs a product built around AI.

In plain words: Some tools sprinkle AI on top; others are designed around it — the difference shows in how central and capable it is.

Example: *An ATS that adds an AI summary button vs one whose whole screening engine is AI.*

Reading an 'AI-powered' claim — Turning a marketing label into checkable questions about what the AI does.

In plain words: Don't take 'AI-powered' at face value — ask what it does, on what data, how well, and with what oversight.

Example: *'AI screening' → 'screens on what criteria, how accurately, tested for bias, can a human override?'*

Human-in-the-loop (in a tool) — The tool keeps a person in control of consequential AI-influenced decisions.

In plain words: A well-designed tool lets AI suggest, but leaves the person-affecting decision to a human.

Example: *The tool's AI ranks candidates; a recruiter must review before anyone is rejected.*

Buy vs build vs augment — Adopt a tool, create your own, or add AI to existing systems.

In plain words: Three ways to get an AI capability: rent a proven one, build a small one, or upgrade what you have.

Example: *Buy an ATS with proven AI; build a no-code AI screening helper; augment your HRMS with an AI query bot.*

FRAMEWORK

Judging AI in a tool: identify the form (ML / generative / agentic) → ask what it does, on what data, how accurately, with what human override and bias testing → decide whether to trust, verify further, or ignore the claim.

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Open two real tools' product pages in your field; list every AI claim and rewrite each as a question you'd test.
2. For your field, name one tool task where AI genuinely helps and one where a human must keep control — and why.
3. Decide, for one AI capability your field needs, whether you would buy, build or augment — and justify it.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why does 'AI-powered' on a vendor page tell you almost nothing on its own?
2. When does an AI feature inside a tool quietly become a consequential decision that should have stayed human?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- A current independent review (e.g., G2/Capterra) of an 'AI' tool in your field — read the AI claims critically.
- Miranda Bogen, "All the Ways Hiring Algorithms Can Introduce Bias," Harvard Business Review (2019).

Hour 4 The HR SaaS Landscape & the Six Fields

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 25 min landscape tour · 15 min field choice · 10 min team planning*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Map the major HR SaaS categories and what each does.
- Recognise representative tools (global and India) in each field.
- Commit to one field to carry through the rest of the course.

TEACHING NOTES

Give students a tour of the HR SaaS landscape, organised around the six fields they can choose from. For each, explain what the category does, the kind of problems it solves, and a few representative tools so students know where to start researching. Stress that the lists are starting points, not endorsements — the market changes fast and part of the course is learning to research the current options themselves.

Walk the six fields. Recruitment / ATS: manage hiring from job post to offer (applicant tracking, screening, scheduling). Performance management: goals/OKRs, reviews, continuous feedback. HRMS / core HR: the system of record — employee data, leave, attendance, onboarding, often payroll. Employee engagement: pulse surveys, recognition, sentiment, action planning. Surveys: designing and analysing employee surveys specifically. Payroll: salary processing, statutory compliance (in India: PF, ESI, PT, TDS), payslips.

Note the India context, since graduates here will often work with India-relevant tools: alongside global platforms (Workday, SAP SuccessFactors, BambooHR, Rippling), there is a strong Indian ecosystem (Darwinbox, Keka, greytHR, Zoho People/Payroll, PeopleStrong, RazorpayX Payroll, ZingHR, HROne) built around Indian statutory compliance. Good research compares both.

Then run the field-choice moment: each team commits to one field and one rough 'target organisation' type (e.g., a 500-person services firm, a fast-growing startup, a hospital) that will frame their needs-gathering. Capture choices so the course can be sequenced around them. End with the reference table below, which students will extend through their own research.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 4 · The HR SaaS Landscape & the Six Fields

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

Applicant Tracking System (ATS) — Software that manages hiring from application to offer.

In plain words: The recruitment workhorse: posts jobs, collects applicants, tracks them through stages.

Example: *Greenhouse or Workable tracking candidates through screen → interview → offer.*

HRMS / core HR — The system of record for employee data and core processes.

In plain words: The central people database plus leave, attendance, onboarding — often the hub of the stack.

Example: *Keka or Darwinbox holding employee records and handling leave and onboarding.*

Engagement vs survey tools — Engagement platforms track and act on morale continuously; survey tools design and analyse specific surveys.

In plain words: Engagement tools are ongoing pulse-and-act systems; survey tools are for running particular surveys well.
Example: *Culture Amp (engagement) vs Qualtrics or a focused survey of one policy change.*

Payroll & compliance — Processing salaries and meeting statutory obligations.
In plain words: Pays people correctly and on time, and handles the legal deductions and filings.
Example: *RazorpayX Payroll or greytHR auto-calculating PF, ESI, PT and TDS in India.*

FRAMEWORK

Choose your field deliberately: pick one of the six, name a target-organisation type, and note one or two problems in that field you find interesting — this becomes the brief you research, select for, implement and prototype.

THE SIX FIELDS — STARTER MAP (RESEARCH AND EXTEND THESE)

Field	What it does	Example tools (global / India)	Example AI use
Recruitment / ATS	Hiring from job post to offer	Greenhouse, Lever, Workable / Naukri RMS, Keka Hire	Resume screening, interview scheduling
Performance mgmt	Goals/OKRs, reviews, feedback	Lattice, 15Five, Betterworks / Peoplebox, Darwinbox	Drafting feedback, summarising reviews
HRMS / core HR	System of record, leave, onboarding	Workday, BambooHR, Rippling / Darwinbox, Keka, Zoho People	HR query chatbot, anomaly checks
Employee engagement	Pulse surveys, recognition, action	Culture Amp, Viva Glint / inFeedo Amber, Vantage Circle	Sentiment analysis, action suggestions
Surveys	Design & analyse employee surveys	Qualtrics, SurveyMonkey / CultureMonkey, Zoho Survey	Theming open comments, driver analysis
Payroll	Salary processing & compliance	ADP, Gusto / RazorpayX Payroll, greytHR, Zoho Payroll	Payroll query bot, error/anomaly detection

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Commit your team to one field and a target-organisation type; write a two-line brief describing the problem you want to address.
2. From the table, pick three tools in your field and note one distinctive feature of each from their websites.
3. Find one tool NOT in the table that fits your field — proving you can research beyond a given list.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why might the 'best' tool differ for a 50-person startup versus a 5,000-person enterprise in the same field?

2. Why should you treat any ‘top tools’ list (including this one) as a starting point, not an answer?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- Two current ‘best [your field] software’ round-ups from independent review sites (e.g., G2, Capterra) — read critically.
- One analyst overview of your field’s category (e.g., a Gartner/Forrester summary or reputable buyer’s guide).

Hour 5 How to Research Tools Like an Analyst

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 25 min teaching · 20 min practical research*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Identify credible sources for researching SaaS tools and judge their reliability.
- Separate marketing claims from evidence.
- Build a structured longlist for a chosen field.

TEACHING NOTES

Teach research as a skill, because most students default to a single Google search and a vendor's own website. Lay out the credible sources and what each is good for: independent analyst reports (e.g., Gartner Magic Quadrant, Forrester Wave) for market structure and serious players; review platforms (G2, Capterra, TrustRadius) for real-user feedback and ratings — read sceptically, watching for incentivised reviews; vendor sites for feature detail and pricing (treat as marketing); product demos and free trials for hands-on truth; and peer references and case studies for real-world outcomes. Triangulating across several beats trusting any one.

Teach how to separate marketing from substance. Every vendor claims to be intuitive, powerful and AI-driven; the analyst's job is to convert claims into checkable questions — 'what exactly does the AI do, on what data, with what oversight?', 'which systems does it integrate with, natively?', 'what does it actually cost at our size, all-in?'. Note common traps: cherry-picked testimonials, 'up to' statistics, feature lists that hide what's only on the priciest tier, and reviews that may be incentivised.

Introduce the longlist: a broad first list of candidate tools in the field (say 8–12), gathered from multiple sources, captured in a simple sheet with a few notes each (target size, headline features, rough pricing, India-relevance). The longlist is later narrowed to a shortlist for deeper evaluation — the funnel of tool selection.

Keep it hands-on: the practical is the start of real research that feeds Module 3. End by reminding students to record their sources, so their later recommendation is defensible — 'we found this on the vendor site' and 'three independent reviews said this' carry very different weight.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 5 · How to Research Tools Like an Analyst

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

Source triangulation — Cross-checking a tool across analysts, reviews, vendor info and references.

In plain words: Believe something only when several independent sources agree, not one marketing page.

Example: A feature claimed by the vendor and confirmed by user reviews and a demo is trustworthy.

Analyst reports vs review sites — Analysts assess market structure and players; review sites capture user feedback.

In plain words: Analysts tell you who the serious players are; review sites tell you what real users feel.

Example: A Gartner quadrant shows leaders; G2 reviews flag a clunky mobile app.

Claim vs evidence — Turning a marketing assertion into a checkable question.

In plain words: Don't accept 'AI-powered' — ask exactly what the AI does and prove it.

Example: 'AI screening' → 'screens on what criteria? tested for bias? human review?'

Longlist → shortlist — A broad candidate list narrowed to a few for deep evaluation.

In plain words: Start wide, then cut to the few worth a serious look.

Example: Twelve candidate ATS tools → a shortlist of three to score in detail.

FRAMEWORK

The research funnel: scan multiple sources → capture a longlist (8–12) with notes → convert claims to questions → cite your sources → narrow to a shortlist for scoring (Module 3).

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Build a longlist of 8–12 tools in your field in a sheet, noting source, target size, headline features and rough pricing for each.
2. Pick one vendor claim and write the three evidence-questions you would use to verify it.
3. Rate each source you used for reliability (high/medium/low) and say why.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why might a five-star review site still mislead you? What would you look for to judge review credibility?
2. How could relying only on a vendor's website lead a manager to a poor decision?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- Overview pages explaining the Gartner Magic Quadrant and Forrester Wave methodologies.
- G2 / Capterra category pages for your field — practise reading reviews critically.

Module 2 · Gathering Needs & Defining Requirements

Before choosing any tool: understand the organisation and turn its needs into clear requirements.

Hour 6 Understanding the Organisation & Mapping the As-Is

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 25 min teaching · 20 min practical mapping*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Identify the stakeholders in an HR tech decision and their differing interests.
- Map an organisation's current ('as-is') process and its pain points.
- Locate where a tool could actually add value.

TEACHING NOTES

Shift the focus from tools to needs, the discipline that separates good buyers from gadget-chasers. The cardinal rule: understand the problem before shopping for a solution. Many failed HR-tech projects bought an impressive tool that did not fit how the organisation actually works. So the course now teaches students to gather needs before selecting anything.

Start with stakeholders — the people with a stake in the decision, who rarely want the same things. In an HR tech project these typically include the HR team (who run the process), employees and managers (who use it), leadership/finance (who pay and want ROI), IT/security (who worry about data and integration), and sometimes a works council or legal. A tool that delights HR but frustrates managers, or that finance won't fund, will fail. Mapping stakeholders and their interests early prevents this.

Teach as-is process mapping: drawing how a process actually works today, step by step, before imagining how a tool would change it. For a recruitment example: requisition → post → screen → interview → offer → onboard, noting who does each step, how long it takes, and where it breaks. Mapping the current state surfaces the real pain points — the bottlenecks, manual steps, errors and frustrations a tool should fix — in the organisation's own words.

Connect pain points to value: a tool is worth buying only where it relieves a real, costly pain. End with a practical where teams map the as-is process for their chosen field in a fictional target organisation (provided), mark the pain points, and note which a tool could plausibly address — the raw material for requirements next session.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 6 · Understanding the Organisation & Mapping the As-Is

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

Stakeholders — The people with an interest in the decision and its outcome.

In plain words: Everyone the tool affects or who must approve it — and they want different things.

Example: *HR wants efficiency, managers want simplicity, finance wants ROI, IT wants security.*

As-is process map — A step-by-step picture of how a process works today.

In plain words: How things actually happen now, drawn out, before you change anything.

Example: *Mapping today's leave-approval flow reveals three manual hand-offs and a two-day delay.*

Pain point — A specific, costly frustration or breakdown in the current process.

In plain words: Where the current way hurts — slow, error-prone, manual or frustrating.

Example: *Recruiters lose candidates because scheduling interviews by email takes a week.*

Problem-before-solution — Understanding the need before shopping for a tool.

In plain words: Diagnose first; a tool bought before you understand the problem usually misfits.

Example: *Buying a flashy ATS that doesn't fix the real bottleneck — slow manager feedback — wastes money.*

FRAMEWORK

As-is analysis: list stakeholders and their interests → map the current process step by step → mark pain points (slow, manual, error-prone, frustrating) → note which a tool could realistically relieve.

PRACTICAL WORK

1. For your target organisation and field, list the stakeholders and one core interest of each.
2. Map the current process for your field in 5–8 steps, marking who does each and where it breaks.
3. Pick the three sharpest pain points and note, for each, the value of fixing it.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why do tools that please HR but ignore managers or employees so often fail?
2. How could mapping the as-is process change which tool — or whether any tool — you end up recommending?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- A short guide to business-process mapping / process flowcharts (any reputable BA resource).
- A stakeholder-analysis primer (e.g., a stakeholder map / interest grid explainer).

Hour 7 Requirements Gathering Techniques

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 25 min teaching · 20 min practical*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Apply core techniques to elicit requirements from stakeholders.
- Distinguish functional from non-functional requirements.
- Prioritise requirements with MoSCoW.

TEACHING NOTES

Teach how to actually extract what people need, since stakeholders rarely hand you a tidy list. The main techniques: interviews (one-to-one, to go deep with key stakeholders); surveys (to gather needs at scale); workshops (to align groups and resolve conflicts); job-shadowing/observation (to see what people really do, not what they say); and reviewing existing documents and data. Each suits a different situation; good analysts combine them. Crucially, ask about problems and goals, not features — people will list the features of tools they've seen rather than their underlying needs.

Distinguish the two types of requirement. Functional requirements are what the tool must do ('let a manager approve leave from their phone', 'screen resumes against job criteria'). Non-functional requirements are how well it must do it and the constraints around it ('handle 5,000 employees', 'comply with the DPDP Act', 'integrate with our payroll', 'be usable by non-technical staff', '99.9% uptime'). Beginners capture functions and forget non-functionals — yet security, integration and scalability often decide success.

Teach prioritisation with MoSCoW: sort requirements into Must-have (non-negotiable), Should-have (important but not vital), Could-have (nice if cheap), and Won't-have (out of scope for now). Without prioritisation every requirement looks essential and no tool can satisfy them all; MoSCoW forces the hard choices that make selection possible.

Keep it practical: the techniques will be used live next session in a needs-gathering workshop. End with a practical where teams draft an interview guide and a short requirements survey for their field, and classify a set of sample needs as functional or non-functional and by MoSCoW priority.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 7 · Requirements Gathering Techniques

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

Elicitation techniques — Interviews, surveys, workshops, observation and document review used to gather needs.

In plain words: The ways you pull real needs out of people — ask, observe, and read, not guess.

Example: *Interview the HR head, survey managers, and shadow a recruiter for an afternoon.*

Functional vs non-functional — What the tool must do vs how well and under what constraints.

In plain words: Functional = the features; non-functional = the speed, security, scale and fit around them.

Example: *'Approve leave on mobile' (functional); 'comply with DPDP and integrate with payroll' (non-functional).*

Ask needs, not features — Eliciting underlying problems and goals rather than tool features.

In plain words: People name features they've seen; dig for the real problem behind the request.

Example: 'We want AI screening' really means 'we can't handle the volume of applicants fairly'.

MoSCoW — Prioritising requirements as Must / Should / Could / Won't-have.

In plain words: Sort needs by how essential they are, so you don't treat everything as critical.

Example: 'Payroll compliance' = Must; 'gamified badges' = Could.

FRAMEWORK

Requirements gathering: choose techniques to fit stakeholders → ask about problems/goals → capture functional AND non-functional needs → prioritise with MoSCoW.

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Draft a 6–8 question interview guide for the key stakeholder in your field, focused on problems and goals.
2. Write a short requirements survey (5–7 questions) you could send to managers/employees.
3. Take ten sample needs and label each functional or non-functional, then assign a MoSCoW priority.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why do non-functional requirements (security, integration, scale) so often decide whether a tool succeeds?
2. How would your questions differ when interviewing an executive versus a frontline user?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- A concise guide to requirements elicitation techniques (any reputable business-analysis source).
- A short explainer on the MoSCoW prioritisation method.

Hour 8 Writing Requirements & Success Criteria

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 25 min teaching · 20 min practical drafting*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Write clear requirements as user stories and use cases.
- Define measurable success criteria for a tool decision.
- Assemble a concise requirements document / lightweight RFP.

TEACHING NOTES

Teach students to write requirements down clearly, because a need that isn't written precisely cannot be evaluated against tools. Introduce the user story format — 'As a [role], I want to [do something], so that [benefit]' — which keeps requirements anchored to a user and a purpose ('As a hiring manager, I want to review shortlisted candidates on my phone, so that I can give feedback within a day'). For more complex flows, a short use case (the steps to achieve a goal) adds detail.

Stress success criteria — how you will know the tool worked. Vague goals ('improve hiring') can't be evaluated; measurable criteria can ('cut time-to-fill from 45 to 30 days', 'reach 90% manager adoption in three months', 'zero payroll-compliance errors'). Success criteria do double duty: they sharpen requirements now and become the yardstick for the implementation later.

Show how the pieces assemble into a requirements document (and how it relates to a formal RFP — request for proposal — that organisations send to vendors). A lightweight requirements doc contains: the business context and goals, stakeholders, the prioritised functional and non-functional requirements (MoSCoW), constraints (budget, timeline, compliance), and the success criteria. This document drives the whole selection and is a real, employer-relevant artifact.

Keep it concrete and tied to the studio next session, where teams will produce this document. End with a practical writing several user stories and a first set of success criteria for the chosen field, ready to fold into the requirements document.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 8 · Writing Requirements & Success Criteria

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

User story — A requirement framed as: As a [role], I want to [action], so that [benefit].

In plain words: A one-line need tied to who wants it and why.

Example: *'As a new hire, I want to complete onboarding forms online, so that I can start on day one without paperwork.'*

Use case — The sequence of steps by which a user achieves a goal with the tool.

In plain words: A short script of how someone gets a task done in the system.

Example: *Manager logs in → opens review → enters ratings → submits → employee is notified.*

Success criteria — Measurable signs that the tool achieved its purpose.

In plain words: The numbers that will tell you it worked — set before you choose.

Example: *'Time-to-fill drops to 30 days; 90% of managers use it within 3 months.'*

Requirements document / RFP — The assembled, prioritised statement of needs that drives selection.

In plain words: The single document of context, needs, constraints and success measures you evaluate tools against.

Example: *A 3–4 page brief HR could hand to vendors or use to score options.*

FRAMEWORK

Requirements doc contents: business context & goals · stakeholders · prioritised functional & non-functional requirements (MoSCoW) · constraints (budget, timeline, compliance) · measurable success criteria.

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Write five user stories for your field, covering at least two different roles.
2. Draft four measurable success criteria for adopting a tool in your field.
3. Outline the section headings of your requirements document and note one line under each.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why do measurable success criteria make both selection and implementation more honest?
2. What is the risk of a requirements document that lists only features and no success criteria?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- A guide to writing user stories and acceptance criteria (any reputable agile/BA source).
- A sample HR software RFP template (search 'HR software RFP template') — study its structure.

Hour 9 ★ Studio — Needs-Gathering Workshop

AT A GLANCE *10 min set-up · 35 min team work · 15 min mentor check-ins*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Run a needs-gathering exercise end to end for the chosen field.
- Produce a complete, prioritised requirements document.
- Practise turning messy stakeholder input into clear requirements.

FACILITATION NOTES

This is the first full studio session. Teams apply Sessions 6–8 to produce the foundational artifact of the course: a requirements document for their chosen field and target organisation. Provide each team with a short 'organisation pack' — a fictional company profile plus two or three dummy stakeholder 'interview transcripts' (or run live role-play interviews where the evaluator or peers play stakeholders) — so teams have realistic, conflicting input to work from.

Circulate as a mentor while teams work: push them to map the as-is process, separate genuine needs from feature wish-lists, capture non-functional requirements (not just features), and prioritise with MoSCoW. Challenge vague success criteria and unstated assumptions, exactly as a real client or sponsor would.

The deliverable is a concise requirements document (3–4 pages) that every later stage will build on — it drives the tool scoring in Module 3 and the implementation in Module 4. Reserve the final minutes for quick mentor check-ins so each team leaves with clear feedback and next steps.

STUDIO BRIEF

Hour 9 · Studio — Needs-Gathering Workshop

Produce the requirements document that anchors your whole project. Work from the organisation pack and stakeholder inputs provided.

STEPS

1. Map the as-is process for your field and mark the pain points.
2. Identify stakeholders and capture their (often conflicting) needs from the inputs provided.
3. Separate functional from non-functional requirements; write the key ones as user stories.
4. Prioritise every requirement with MoSCoW and note constraints (budget, timeline, compliance).
5. Define 3–5 measurable success criteria.
6. Assemble the requirements document and sanity-check it against the original pain points.

DELIVERABLE

A 3–4 page requirements document (context & goals, stakeholders, prioritised functional & non-functional requirements, constraints, success criteria). Submitted for assessment and used in all later stages.

TIPS

- Resist naming any tool yet — stay on needs.
- If a stakeholder asks for a feature, trace it back to the underlying problem.
- Make every success criterion a number you could later check.

EVALUATOR FOCUS

Did the team gather genuine needs (not feature wish-lists), capture non-functional requirements, prioritise honestly with MoSCoW, and set measurable success criteria?

Module 3 · Researching, Evaluating & Selecting Tools

Research the market like an analyst, score tools against needs, and recommend with evidence.

Hour 10 ★ Building a Longlist & Shortlist in Your Field

AT A GLANCE *10 min method recap · 35 min team research · 15 min mentor review*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Apply research skills to build a credible longlist in the chosen field.
- Narrow the longlist to a defensible shortlist tied to requirements.
- Document sources so the selection is defensible.

FACILITATION NOTES

A working research session that turns the requirements document into a candidate set of tools. Teams use the research methods from Session 5 — analysts, review sites, vendor info, demos, references — to build a longlist of 8–12 tools in their field, including both global and India-relevant options where appropriate, captured in a structured sheet with notes and sources.

Then teams narrow the longlist to a shortlist (typically three) using their requirements as the filter — dropping tools that obviously fail a Must-have, target the wrong organisation size, or fall outside budget/compliance constraints. The discipline is to narrow against the requirements, not against gut feel or marketing gloss; teams should be able to say why each cut tool was cut.

Mentor focus is on research quality and traceability: are the sources credible and varied, are claims checked, and does the shortlist clearly follow from the requirements? End with mentor review so teams enter the scoring sessions with a sound shortlist. The starter table below (built from current market research) is a launch pad — teams must extend and verify it themselves.

STUDIO BRIEF

Hour 10 · Building a Longlist & Shortlist in Your Field

Build a researched longlist, then narrow to a shortlist of ~3 tools justified by your requirements. Cite every source.

STARTER TOOL SHORTLIST BY FIELD (RESEARCH, VERIFY AND EXTEND — NOT ENDORSEMENTS)

Field	Global examples	India-relevant examples
Recruitment / ATS	Greenhouse, Lever, Workable, SmartRecruiters	Naukri RMS, Keka Hire, Zoho Recruit
Performance mgmt	Lattice, 15Five, Betterworks, Culture Amp	Peoplebox, Darwinbox, Zoho People
HRMS / core HR	Workday, BambooHR, Rippling, HiBob, SAP SuccessFactors	Darwinbox, Keka, greytHR, Zoho People, HROne
Employee engagement	Culture Amp, Microsoft Viva Glint, Officevibe	inFeedo Amber, Vantage Circle, CultureMonkey
Surveys	Qualtrics, SurveyMonkey, Typeform	CultureMonkey, Zoho Survey, Google Forms
Payroll	ADP, Gusto, Paychex	RazorpayX Payroll, greytHR, Zoho

Field	Global examples	India-relevant examples
		Payroll, Keka

STEPS

1. Gather 8–12 candidate tools from at least three source types (analyst, reviews, vendor, references).
2. For each, note target size, headline features, rough pricing, India-relevance and source.
3. Filter against your Must-have requirements and constraints to drop clear non-fits.
4. Choose ~3 shortlisted tools and write one line on why each survived and why others were cut.

DELIVERABLE

A longlist sheet (8–12 tools with notes & sources) and a justified shortlist of ~3 tools mapped to your requirements.

TIPS

- Treat any 'top tools' list (including the starter table) as a beginning, not an answer — verify independently.
- Watch for tools that look great but target a very different organisation size.
- Keep a sources column — you will defend this at Demo 1.

EVALUATOR FOCUS

Are sources credible and varied? Does the shortlist follow logically from the requirements rather than from marketing?

Hour 11 Evaluation Criteria & Total Cost of Ownership

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 25 min teaching · 20 min practical*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Build a complete set of tool-evaluation criteria.
- Explain and estimate total cost of ownership (TCO).
- Tie evaluation criteria back to the requirements.

TEACHING NOTES

Teach what to evaluate a tool on, so scoring (next session) rests on the right criteria. A complete set usually spans: functional fit (does it meet the Must/Should requirements?), usability (will people actually use it?), integration (does it connect to the existing stack?), security & compliance (data protection, certifications, statutory compliance), scalability (will it grow with the organisation?), vendor viability & support (is the vendor stable; is support good?), implementation effort, AI capability (real and responsible, not hype), and cost. Criteria should derive from the requirements — a tool is evaluated against what this organisation needs, not against a generic feature list.

Spend real time on total cost of ownership (TCO), which beginners underestimate by looking only at the sticker (per-seat) price. TCO includes subscription fees, implementation and configuration cost, data-migration effort, integration work, training, ongoing administration, and the cost of any add-on modules that turn out to be essential. A ‘cheaper’ tool with heavy implementation and hidden module costs can exceed a pricier all-inclusive one. Estimating TCO over, say, three years gives a fair comparison.

Warn about criteria traps: over-weighting flashy features no one needs, ignoring usability (the commonest cause of low adoption), and treating ‘AI’ as a plus without asking what it does. Each criterion should matter to this decision and connect to a requirement or constraint.

End with a practical where teams turn their requirements into a weighted criteria list (which feeds directly into the scoring matrix next session) and sketch a rough three-year TCO for one shortlisted tool.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 11 · Evaluation Criteria & Total Cost of Ownership

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

Evaluation criteria — The dimensions on which competing tools are judged.

In plain words: The yardsticks — fit, usability, integration, security, scale, vendor, AI, cost — you score tools against.

Example: Scoring three ATS tools on functional fit, integration and TCO, among others.

Functional fit — How well a tool meets the prioritised functional requirements.

In plain words: Does it actually do the Must- and Should-have things you need?

Example: An ATS that can’t do structured interview scorecards fails a Must-have.

Total cost of ownership (TCO) — All costs over time: subscription, implementation, migration, integration, training, admin, add-ons.

In plain words: The true all-in cost over a few years — not just the monthly per-seat price.

Example: *A 'cheap' tool needing costly setup and paid add-ons can beat a pricier all-inclusive one.*

Usability & adoption — How easily real users can use the tool, which drives whether it's adopted.

In plain words: If people find it clunky, they won't use it — and an unused tool delivers nothing.

Example: *Managers abandon a powerful but confusing review tool, so reviews don't get done.*

FRAMEWORK

Evaluation criteria (derive from requirements): functional fit · usability · integration · security & compliance · scalability · vendor viability & support · implementation effort · AI capability · TCO.

COMMON EVALUATION CRITERIA AND WHAT TO CHECK

Criterion	What to check
Functional fit	Meets Must/Should requirements; covers core workflows
Usability	Clean UI, mobile, low training need, good user reviews
Integration	Native connectors/APIs to your stack (e.g., payroll, HRMS)
Security & compliance	Certifications, data residency, DPDP/GDPR, statutory (PF/ESI/TDS)
Scalability & vendor	Grows with you; stable vendor; quality support; references
AI capability	What the AI does, on what data, with what human oversight
Total cost of ownership	Subscription + implementation + migration + training + add-ons over 3 yrs

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Turn your requirements into a weighted criteria list (assign each criterion a weight that sums to 100%).
2. Sketch a rough three-year TCO for one shortlisted tool, listing every cost component you can find.
3. Identify one criterion vendors will try to win on with hype, and how you'll judge it on substance.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why does the cheapest sticker price often not mean the lowest total cost?
2. Why is usability sometimes more important than having the most features?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- A guide to software TCO for buyers (any reputable procurement/IT source).
- A sample HR software evaluation-criteria checklist (search and compare two).

Hour 12 The Weighted Scoring Matrix

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 20 min worked example · 25 min build their own*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Build a weighted scoring matrix to compare tools objectively.
- Apply weights that reflect requirement priorities.
- Interpret the result without letting the number override judgement.

TEACHING NOTES

Teach the single most useful selection tool: the weighted scoring matrix (decision matrix). It lays criteria down the side with a weight each (reflecting how important that criterion is), and the shortlisted tools across the top. Each tool is scored on each criterion (say 1–5); each score is multiplied by the criterion's weight; the weighted scores are summed to give each tool a total. It turns a messy, opinion-driven debate into a transparent, defensible comparison.

Work a simple example live so students see the mechanics: a few criteria (functional fit, usability, integration, security, TCO) with weights summing to 100%, three tools scored 1–5, and the weighted totals computed. Show how changing the weights (e.g., if compliance is critical) changes the winner — which is the point: the weights encode the organisation's priorities, so they must be set deliberately and from the requirements, not fiddled to get a desired answer.

Stress honest use. The matrix is a thinking aid, not an oracle: scores are judgements and should be evidence-based (from research and demos), weights should be agreed before scoring (not tuned to favour a pre-chosen tool), and a close result means 'these tools are similar — decide on other grounds', not 'the one 0.1 ahead is objectively best'. Sensitivity (does the winner survive reasonable weight changes?) matters.

This directly powers the studio in Session 15 and Demo 1 in Session 16. End with a practical where teams build the skeleton of their own weighted scoring matrix — criteria, weights from their requirements, and the scoring scale — ready to fill in with researched evidence.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 12 · The Weighted Scoring Matrix

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

Weighted scoring matrix — A grid scoring each tool on weighted criteria to produce a comparable total.

> ***In plain words:*** Score tools on each criterion, multiply by how much that criterion matters, and add up — a fair, visible comparison.
>
> ***Example:*** *Tool A scores 4 on integration (weight 20%) → contributes 0.8 to its total.*

Weights — Numbers reflecting how important each criterion is, summing to 100%.

> ***In plain words:*** How much each yardstick counts — set from the organisation's priorities, before scoring.
>
> ***Example:*** *If compliance is critical, give it a high weight so it drives the result.*

Evidence-based scoring — Scores grounded in research, demos and references, not impressions.

In plain words: Back each score with a reason, not a feeling.

Example: Scoring usability 2 because three user reviews and the demo showed a clunky interface.

Sensitivity check — Testing whether the winner survives reasonable changes to the weights.

In plain words: See if the result holds when you nudge the weights — a robust winner survives; a fragile one doesn't.

Example: If raising the security weight flips the winner, the choice was closer than it looked.

FRAMEWORK

Scoring matrix: criteria (from requirements) × weights (sum 100%) × tool scores (1–5, evidence-based) → weighted totals → sanity-check with a sensitivity test → decide (with judgement).

WORKED EXAMPLE (ILLUSTRATIVE SCORES OUT OF 5)

Criterion (weight)	Tool A	Tool B	Tool C
Functional fit (30%)	5	4	3
Usability (20%)	3	5	4
Integration (20%)	4	3	5
Security/compliance (20%)	4	4	3
TCO (10%) — higher = cheaper	2	3	5
Weighted total (out of 5)	3.9	4.0	3.7

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Build your matrix skeleton: list your criteria, assign weights summing to 100%, and define the 1–5 scale.
2. Score one shortlisted tool on every criterion, writing a one-line evidence note for each score.
3. Change one weight and see whether the likely winner would change — note what that tells you.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why must weights be agreed before scoring, not adjusted afterwards?
2. If two tools score within 0.1 of each other, what does that mean for your recommendation?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- A short guide to decision/weighted-scoring matrices (any reputable decision-making source).
- An example vendor-selection scorecard for software procurement.

Hour 13 Running Demos, POCs & Reference Checks

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 25 min teaching · 20 min practical*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Run an effective vendor demo or proof-of-concept.
- Ask questions that reveal substance behind the sales pitch.
- Use reference checks to validate vendor claims.

TEACHING NOTES

Teach students to evaluate a tool in action, not just on paper. A vendor demo is a sales performance — polished, scripted, showing the tool at its best — so the buyer must take control: provide your own scenario based on your real requirements and ask the vendor to show how the tool handles it, rather than watching a canned tour. A proof-of-concept (POC) or trial goes further, letting your team use the tool with dummy data on your actual use cases.

Equip students with the questions that cut through polish: 'show me how a manager does X on mobile', 'what exactly does the AI do here and can a human override it?', 'what doesn't this do well?', 'what does this cost all-in for our size?', 'which integrations are native vs custom?', 'what happens to our data if we leave?'. Watching how a vendor handles hard questions is itself information.

Introduce reference checks: speaking to existing customers (ideally similar in size and sector) about real experience — implementation pain, support quality, hidden costs, whether it delivered. References the vendor provides are pre-selected, so ask them for others and probe for the downsides. This is where marketing meets reality.

Tie it to the scoring matrix: demos, POCs and references generate the evidence behind the scores. End with a practical where teams write a demo script (their scenario + must-see tasks) and a reference-check question list for their shortlisted tools.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 13 · Running Demos, POCs & Reference Checks

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

Scenario-led demo — Making the vendor demonstrate your real use cases, not their scripted tour.

In plain words: Bring your own scenario and say 'show me how it does this'.

Example: *'Show a manager approving leave on a phone and the payroll updating' — your scenario, their tool.*

Proof-of-concept (POC) / trial — Hands-on use of the tool with your data and use cases.

In plain words: Actually trying the tool yourself with dummy data before committing.

Example: *A two-week trial where your team runs a mock hiring cycle in the ATS.*

Substance questions — Questions that expose real capability, limits, cost and oversight.

In plain words: The hard questions that reveal what the tool truly does and doesn't.

Example: *'What does this NOT do well?' and 'what's the all-in cost at our size?'*

Reference check — Talking to existing customers about their real experience.

In plain words: Ask current users — not just the vendor's hand-picked ones — what it's really like.
Example: *A similar-sized HR head reveals the implementation took twice as long as promised.*

FRAMEWORK

Evaluate in action: lead the demo with your scenario → ask substance & limit questions → run a POC with dummy data if possible → check references for the real story → feed it all into the scoring matrix.

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Write a demo script for one shortlisted tool: your scenario plus 5 must-see tasks.
2. List eight substance questions you would ask the vendor, including cost, AI, integration and exit.
3. Draft six reference-check questions designed to surface downsides and hidden costs.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why is a vendor's standard demo potentially misleading, and how does a scenario-led demo fix that?
2. What can you learn from how a salesperson responds to 'what doesn't this do well?'

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- A short guide to running software vendor demos / POCs as a buyer.
- A reference-check question list for software selection (search and adapt).

Hour 14 Pricing, Contracts, Security & Risk

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 25 min teaching · 20 min practical*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Decode common SaaS pricing models and spot hidden costs.
- Recognise contract and data red flags.
- Assess security, privacy and exit risk before committing.

TEACHING NOTES

Cover the commercial and risk side that turns a good tool choice into a safe one. Pricing models vary: per-user (per-seat) per month is most common; tiered plans bundle features by level (watch for the feature you need sitting only in the top tier); usage-based charges by volume; and implementation/setup fees are often separate. Free trials and freemium tiers help students learn. The lesson: compare on total cost of ownership, not headline price, and read what each tier actually includes.

Walk through contract red flags managers should recognise (without being lawyers): long lock-in terms with auto-renewal, steep price escalation after year one, charges for data export, weak data-ownership or privacy clauses, and vague service levels. The course isn't legal training, but future managers should know which clauses to flag for legal/procurement review.

Address security and privacy concretely. Check where data is stored (residency), the vendor's certifications (e.g., ISO 27001, SOC 2), breach history, and compliance with applicable law — India's DPDP Act and the EU's GDPR. For HR data especially (pay, performance, health), this is non-negotiable. And always ask the exit question: how do we get our data out and what does leaving cost — the antidote to lock-in.

Frame all of this as risk assessment feeding the decision: a slightly weaker tool with far lower risk may be the better choice. End with a practical where teams identify the pricing model and likely hidden costs of a shortlisted tool, and list the contract/security questions they would escalate before signing.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 14 · Pricing, Contracts, Security & Risk

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

Pricing models — Per-user, tiered, usage-based, plus setup/implementation fees.

In plain words: The different ways SaaS charges you — and where the real cost can hide.

Example: A tool is ₹100/user/month, but the feature you need is only in the top tier at ₹250.

Contract red flags — Auto-renewal lock-in, price escalation, data-export charges, weak data/privacy terms.

In plain words: Clauses that can trap you, raise costs, or weaken your control of your data.

Example: A 3-year auto-renewing contract with a 15% annual price rise and an exit data-export fee.

Security & privacy due diligence — Checking residency, certifications, breach history and legal compliance.

In plain words: Confirming your sensitive people data will be safe and lawful in the vendor's hands.

Example: Verifying DPDP compliance and ISO 27001 before putting payroll data in a tool.

Exit / data portability — How easily and cheaply you can leave with your data.

In plain words: Your escape route — always know it before you commit.

Example: Confirming you can export all employee data in a standard format at no charge.

FRAMEWORK

Commercial & risk check: decode the pricing model → estimate TCO incl. hidden costs → flag contract red flags → verify security, residency & compliance → confirm the exit route. A lower-risk tool can beat a slightly better but riskier one.

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Identify the pricing model and three likely hidden costs for one shortlisted tool.
2. List five contract clauses you would ask legal/procurement to review before signing.
3. Write the security, residency and compliance questions for your field (include DPDP if Indian data).

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why can a long lock-in contract be dangerous even for a tool you love today?
2. Why is the 'how do we get our data out?' question one of the most important a buyer can ask?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- A primer on SaaS pricing models and hidden costs.
- India DPDP Act and EU GDPR summaries focused on employee/HR data obligations.

Hour 15 ★ Studio — Tool Research & Scoring

AT A GLANCE *10 min set-up · 35 min team scoring · 15 min mentor review*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Complete a full weighted scoring matrix for the shortlisted tools.
- Ground every score in researched evidence.
- Reach and justify a tool recommendation.

FACILITATION NOTES

A working studio where teams pull together everything in Module 3 into a finished evaluation. Using their requirements-derived criteria and weights, teams score each shortlisted tool, backing every score with evidence gathered from research, demos/trials and (where possible) references. The output is a completed weighted scoring matrix plus a clear recommendation.

Mentor through the common failure modes: scores that are guesses rather than evidence-based; weights quietly tuned to favour a pre-chosen tool; ignoring TCO or risk; and treating a razor-thin score gap as a definitive winner. Push teams to run a quick sensitivity check and to be honest where tools are close.

Teams also prepare the spine of their Demo 1 story: the need, the shortlist, the scoring, the recommendation and its justification (including cost and risk). Reserve time for mentor review so every team enters Demo 1 with a defensible recommendation and knows where it is weak.

STUDIO BRIEF

Hour 15 · Studio — Tool Research & Scoring

Complete your evaluation: score the shortlist on weighted, requirement-derived criteria with evidence, and reach a justified recommendation.

STEPS

1. Finalise criteria and weights from your requirements (weights sum to 100%).
2. Score each shortlisted tool 1–5 on every criterion, with a one-line evidence note per score.
3. Compute weighted totals and run a sensitivity check on the result.
4. Decide your recommendation; state why, including TCO and key risks.
5. Draft the Demo 1 storyline: need → shortlist → scoring → recommendation → justification.

DELIVERABLE

A completed weighted scoring matrix with evidence notes and a one-page tool recommendation, ready to present at Demo 1.

TIPS

- Every score needs a reason a sceptical client would accept.
- If the top two are within ~0.2, say so and decide on cost/risk — don't fake precision.
- Be ready to defend why you cut the tools you cut.

EVALUATOR FOCUS

Are scores evidence-based and weights honest? Does the recommendation follow from the matrix, TCO and risk — and can the team defend it?

Hour 16 ★ Demo Day 1 — Tool Landscape & Recommendation

AT A GLANCE *5 min set-up · 40 min team demos & Q&A · 15 min peer scoring & evaluator feedback*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Present a researched view of the SaaS tools in your chosen field.
- Recommend a tool for a stated set of needs, justified with evidence.
- Give and receive structured, specific feedback as an evaluator panel.

FACILITATION NOTES

This is the first of three milestone demo days and the payoff for Modules 1–3. Each team presents the landscape of tools in their chosen field, the needs they gathered, their shortlist and weighted scoring, and a clear recommendation. Run it like a real vendor-selection readout to a leadership team: tight, evidence-based, and ending with a decision. The course evaluator and peers form the panel.

Hold teams to the disciplines taught so far: a recommendation must trace back to stated needs and weighted criteria, not to which tool looked flashiest; claims about a tool's features should be backed by research, not marketing copy; and cost should include total cost of ownership, not just the sticker price. Keep demos short so there is real time for questions and feedback, which is where the learning concentrates.

DEMO BRIEF

Hour 16 · Demo Day 1 — Tool Landscape & Recommendation

Present your field's tool landscape and a defensible recommendation to the panel. You are advising a leadership team that must choose where to invest; they want the answer, the evidence, and the trade-offs — in roughly seven minutes, plus questions.

STEPS

1. Open with the decision and your recommendation in one line (lead with the answer), then the field and the organisation's key needs you are solving for.
2. Show the landscape: the main global and India-relevant tools in your field, and how you narrowed a longlist to a shortlist.
3. Show your weighted scoring matrix and walk the panel through why the winning tool scored highest against the needs.
4. Cover cost (TCO), key risks (security, lock-in, India compliance where relevant) and one honest weakness of your pick.
5. Close with the recommendation, the expected benefit, and what you would pilot first.
6. Take panel questions; capture feedback for your implementation phase.

DELIVERABLE

A 6–8 slide recommendation deck plus your completed weighted scoring matrix, submitted after the session. Each non-presenting team submits a peer scorecard.

TIPS

- Recommend, don't describe — a feature tour is not a recommendation; tie everything back to needs.

- Anticipate the panel's hardest question ('why not the cheaper / market-leading option?') and answer it head-on.
- Quote tool capabilities from your research and the vendor's own documentation, not from a sales pitch.

EVALUATOR FOCUS

Does the recommendation follow logically from gathered needs and weighted criteria? Is the evidence real and current? Are cost, risk and a genuine weakness addressed honestly? Is it delivered as a decision, not a description?

Module 4 · Implementing a Tool End-to-End

Take a chosen tool from configuration to go-live on dummy data — the work that wins or wastes the value.

Hour 17 The Implementation Lifecycle

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 25 min teaching · 15 min mapping exercise · 10 min thinking*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Describe the phases of a typical HR SaaS implementation.
- Explain who is involved at each phase and where projects usually fail.
- Map your chosen tool's rollout onto the lifecycle.

TEACHING NOTES

Buying a tool is the easy part; making it live and used is where value is won or lost. Introduce the implementation lifecycle as the backbone of Module 4. A typical HR SaaS rollout moves through: plan and mobilise (scope, team, success criteria); configure and build (set the tool up to fit the agreed process); migrate data (get clean people data in); integrate (connect to payroll, email, identity); test and UAT (prove it works with real scenarios); train (prepare users); go-live and cutover (switch on); and hypercare and optimise (intensive support, then continuous improvement). Most failures are not technical — they are poor scoping, dirty data, weak testing, or neglected change management.

Stress the difference between configuration and customisation. SaaS tools are designed to be configured — set up using built-in options (fields, workflows, roles) — not heavily customised with bespoke code. Over-customising a SaaS product is a classic, expensive mistake: it breaks on upgrades and recreates the very maintenance burden SaaS was meant to remove. The discipline is to adapt the process to the tool's good defaults where possible, and configure only where the business genuinely differs.

Explain the supporting concepts students will use in their own rollout. UAT (user-acceptance testing) means real users test real scenarios before go-live, not just the project team. A cutover is the controlled switch from the old way to the new. Hypercare is the intensive support window just after go-live when issues are fixed fast. Each phase has an owner and a checklist; skipping phases to save time is how go-lives go wrong.

Close by connecting to the studio: in the next sessions each team will actually configure their chosen tool (or a no-code stand-in) on dummy data and run it through a slice of this lifecycle. Have teams map their tool's rollout onto the phases now, naming who would own each phase and the single biggest risk in their field.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 17 · The Implementation Lifecycle

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

Implementation lifecycle — The phases from planning a rollout to steady-state use.

In plain words: The journey from 'we bought it' to 'everyone uses it well'.

Example: *Plan → configure → migrate data → integrate → test/UAT → train → go-live → hypercare.*

Configuration vs customisation — Setting up built-in options vs building bespoke code.

In plain words: Use the tool's switches and settings; avoid bolting on custom code that breaks on upgrades.

Example: *Configuring an approval workflow (good) vs coding a one-off module (risky).*

UAT — User-acceptance testing — real users test real scenarios before go-live.

In plain words: The people who'll actually use it try real tasks and sign off before launch.

Example: *A recruiter runs a full requisition-to-offer cycle on test data and confirms it works.*

Cutover & hypercare — The controlled switch to the new system, then intensive early support.

In plain words: Go-live day, followed by a period of fast firefighting while people settle in.

Example: *Two weeks of daily stand-ups and rapid fixes right after launch.*

FRAMEWORK

The Implementation Lifecycle: Plan → Configure → Migrate → Integrate → Test/UAT → Train → Go-live/Cutover → Hypercare/Optimise. Each phase has an owner, entry/exit criteria, and a top risk.

THE IMPLEMENTATION PHASES, PHASE BY PHASE

Phase	What happens	Who's involved	Common pitfall
Plan & mobilise	Scope, team, success criteria, plan	Sponsor, HR lead, vendor	Vague scope and no success metric
Configure	Set up fields, workflows, roles	HR admin, vendor consultant	Over-customising the SaaS
Migrate data	Map, clean, load people data	HR ops, IT	Loading dirty or unmapped data
Integrate	Connect payroll, email, identity	IT, vendor	Underestimating integration effort
Test / UAT	Real users test real scenarios	End users, project team	Skipping UAT to save time
Train	Prepare users; quick guides	HR, managers	One-off training, no reinforcement
Go-live & hypercare	Cutover, then intensive support	Everyone	No support plan after launch

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Map your chosen tool's rollout onto the eight phases; name an owner and the top risk for each.
2. For your field, list two things you would configure and one thing you should resist customising.
3. Write three UAT scenarios a real user in your field would run before sign-off.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why are most implementation failures organisational (scope, data, change) rather than technical?
2. When is adapting your process to the tool's defaults wiser than bending the tool to your process?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- Josh Bersin, guidance on HR systems implementation (joshbersin.com).

- Vendor implementation guides (e.g., Darwinbox / Keka / Greenhouse) as practitioner references.

Hour 18 ★ Studio — Configure Your Tool

AT A GLANCE *10 min set-up · 35 min hands-on configuration · 15 min mentor check-ins*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Configure a real or stand-in tool to fit your field's core process.
- Set up the organisation structure, key fields, roles and a core workflow.
- Make sensible configuration choices and document them.

FACILITATION NOTES

Hands-on studio: teams now configure the tool they recommended — using a free trial or sandbox where one exists, or a no-code stand-in (a structured spreadsheet or a no-code app builder) where it doesn't — so that everyone gets a real configuration experience regardless of vendor access. The aim is not a full enterprise rollout but a working slice that demonstrates the core process of their field end to end.

Circulate as the evaluator/mentor, helping teams make good configuration choices and resist over-engineering. Push them to set up the essentials for their field: the organisation structure and roles, the key data fields, and one core workflow (e.g., a recruitment requisition→offer flow, a performance review cycle, a leave-request approval, a survey send-and-collect, or a payroll run on dummy data). Documenting choices now makes the Demo 2 walkthrough straightforward.

STUDIO BRIEF

Hour 18 · Studio — Configure Your Tool

Stand up a working configuration of your chosen tool for your field. By the end of the session you should be able to show the organisation set up, the key fields and roles, and one core workflow running on dummy data.

STEPS

1. Set up the basics: organisation/team structure, user roles and permissions, and the key data fields for your field.
2. Configure one core workflow end to end (e.g., requisition→offer, review cycle, leave approval, survey, or a dummy payroll run).
3. Enter a small set of dummy records so the workflow can actually be run and shown.
4. Note every configuration decision and why you made it (you'll need this for Demo 2).
5. Identify anything you wanted to do but the tool couldn't — a useful finding for your evaluation.

DELIVERABLE

A working configured tool (or stand-in) demonstrating your field's core workflow on dummy data, plus a short configuration log of decisions.

TIPS

- Build a thin slice that works end to end rather than a wide setup that does nothing fully.
- Use the tool's defaults wherever they're reasonable — configure, don't customise.

- Keep your dummy data small but realistic enough to make the workflow meaningful.

EVALUATOR FOCUS

Is there a genuine working slice (not just screens set up but never run)? Are configuration choices deliberate and documented? Did the team adapt sensibly to the tool rather than fight it?

Hour 19 Data Migration & Data Quality with Dummy Data

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 25 min teaching · 15 min hands-on · 10 min thinking*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Plan a data migration: map, clean, load and reconcile.
- Create realistic dummy data that exercises a tool properly.
- Explain why data quality decides whether a rollout succeeds.

TEACHING NOTES

Almost every troubled HR system go-live traces back to data. Teach the migration sequence: extract the data from the old source, map each old field to the new tool's field, clean and standardise it, load it (usually via the tool's import template), and reconcile — check that what landed matches what you sent (counts and totals). Skipping reconciliation is how silent data loss happens.

Because students work on dummy data, make creating good dummy data a skill in itself. Dummy data should be realistic in shape (sensible names, IDs, dates, categories, relationships between records) and should deliberately include the messy cases a real migration hits — a duplicate, a missing field, an inconsistent category, an odd date — so the tool's validation and the team's cleaning are actually tested. Clean, perfect dummy data teaches nothing about migration.

Cover data quality and validation: field formats, mandatory fields, valid value lists, and referential checks (e.g., every employee points to a real manager and department). Good tools enforce validation rules on import; the team's job is to fix the data so it passes, not to switch the rules off. Tie this back to privacy — even dummy data should follow the principle of using realistic but not real personal information.

Finish with a short hands-on: teams build a small dummy dataset for their field, deliberately seed a few quality problems, run it through their tool's import (or stand-in), and reconcile the result — experiencing the migration loop they will show in Demo 2.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 19 · Data Migration & Data Quality with Dummy Data

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

Data mapping — Matching each source field to the target tool's field.

In plain words: Deciding where each old column goes in the new system before loading.

Example: *'Emp Code' in the old sheet maps to 'Employee ID' in the new tool.*

Validation rules — Checks the tool enforces on imported data.

In plain words: The system's gatekeeper: formats, mandatory fields and valid values it won't accept without.

Example: *Rejecting a join date in the wrong format or a blank department.*

Reconciliation — Confirming the loaded data matches what was sent.

In plain words: Counting and checking after the load so nothing was silently dropped or mangled.

Example: *200 employees exported, 200 loaded, totals match — reconciled.*

Realistic dummy data — Fake data shaped like the real thing, including messy cases.

In plain words: Made-up records that behave like real ones, with a few deliberate flaws to test cleaning.
Example: *A dummy file with one duplicate and one missing manager, to exercise validation.*

FRAMEWORK

The Migration Loop: Extract → Map → Clean → Load → Reconcile. Never load unmapped or dirty data, and always reconcile counts and totals after loading.

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Build a small dummy dataset for your field, seeding two or three deliberate data-quality problems.
2. Create a field-mapping table from your dummy source to your tool's import template.
3. Load the data, fix what validation rejects, and reconcile the result; note what you changed.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why is reconciliation — not loading — the step most often skipped, and what goes wrong when it is?
2. Why should even dummy data avoid using real people's personal information?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- Practitioner guides on HR data migration and import templates (vendor documentation).
- Bernard Marr, Data-Driven HR (2018) — the data-quality chapter.

Hour 20 Driving Adoption of a New Tool

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 25 min teaching · 15 min planning · 10 min thinking*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Explain why adoption, not installation, determines a tool's success.
- Build a practical adoption playbook for a software rollout.
- Plan stakeholder engagement, communication, training and adoption measurement for your tool.

TEACHING NOTES

A tool that is live but unused has failed. The technical rollout is only half the job; the other half is getting people to actually use the new tool. Many capable HR systems quietly fail because no one drove adoption — managers kept using spreadsheets, employees ignored the portal, and the investment was wasted. This session is squarely about the adoption playbook for a tool rollout: the concrete moves that get a specific piece of software used.

Keep the change theory light and pointed. The broad models of leading organisational change — Kotter's eight steps for the organisation and Prosci's ADKAR for the individual — are treated in depth in the New Age HR course; here we simply borrow their one practical lesson and apply it to software: people adopt a tool when they understand why it exists, can see what's in it for them, know how to use it, are able to, and are reinforced for doing so. We spend our time on execution, not on the frameworks themselves.

Work through the concrete levers of tool adoption. Engage the right stakeholders early — especially the line managers and a few enthusiastic 'super-users' who can model and support the tool. Communicate the change clearly and repeatedly, in the users' language, not HR's. Train in a way that sticks: hands-on, role-specific, with short reference guides and in-tool help, never a single forgotten session. Surface resistance honestly and treat it as information about real problems with the tool or process. And measure adoption — logins, active users, workflow-completion rates — so you can see exactly where uptake is lagging and intervene there. Adoption is the leading indicator of whether the tool's promised benefits will ever appear.

Have teams draft an adoption plan for their own tool rollout: the key stakeholders and super-users, the one-line 'why' for users, the training approach, the likely resistance, and the single adoption metric they will watch after go-live. This plan becomes part of their Demo 2 story.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 20 · Driving Adoption of a New Tool

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

Adoption — People actually using the tool as intended.

In plain words: The real measure of success — not whether it's installed, but whether it's used well.

Example: 80% of managers completing reviews in the tool, not in side spreadsheets.

Super-users — A few trained, enthusiastic users who model and support the tool for peers.

In plain words: Local champions who help colleagues and show the tool is worth using.

Example: Two recruiters who learn the ATS first and coach the rest of the team.

Role-specific training — Training built around what each user actually does in the tool.

In plain words: Teach managers the manager tasks and recruiters the recruiter tasks — not a generic tour.

Example: A 20-minute hands-on session on just the three things managers must do, plus a one-page guide.

Adoption metrics — Measures of real usage that flag where uptake lags.

In plain words: Numbers like active users and workflow completion that show who's really using it.

Example: One team's logins near zero — a signal to intervene there.

FRAMEWORK

Tool-adoption playbook: engage stakeholders & super-users → communicate the 'why' → train role-by-role so it sticks → treat resistance as information → measure adoption → reinforce. (Change-leadership theory — Kotter, ADKAR — is covered in the New Age HR course.)

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Draft a one-page adoption plan for your tool: stakeholders, super-users, the 'why', training approach, likely resistance.
2. Write the single most persuasive sentence telling a sceptical manager why to use your tool.
3. Choose the one adoption metric you would watch weekly after go-live, and your trigger for acting.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why does a technically perfect tool rollout still fail if adoption is neglected?
2. Is user resistance always a problem to overcome, or sometimes useful feedback about the tool? Give an example.

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- A practitioner guide to software user-adoption / change-enablement (e.g., a vendor adoption playbook).
- A short piece on the role of super-users / champions in technology rollouts.

Hour 21 Testing, Go-Live & Measuring Success

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 25 min teaching · 15 min planning · 10 min thinking*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Plan testing and a go-live readiness check for a tool.
- Run a controlled cutover and a hypercare period.
- Define how you will measure whether the implementation succeeded.

TEACHING NOTES

Bring the implementation module to its conclusion: proving the tool works, switching it on safely, and knowing whether it paid off. Cover the testing types in plain terms — functional testing (does each feature work?), end-to-end testing (does a whole process run?), and UAT (do real users accept it on real scenarios?). Testing is cheap insurance; a defect found in testing costs far less than one found by an angry user at go-live.

Teach a go-live readiness check: a short, honest checklist answered before launch — is the data reconciled, is UAT signed off, are users trained, is support ready, is there a rollback plan if it goes wrong? A controlled cutover (often over a weekend or in a phased rollout) reduces risk, and a hypercare period of intensive support immediately after catches the inevitable early issues before they sour adoption.

Make the measuring-success point firmly, linking back to the needs and success criteria set in Module 2. An implementation succeeds only if it delivers the benefits it promised — so success must be measured against those criteria, not against 'we went live on time'. Distinguish adoption metrics (is it being used?) from outcome metrics (did it improve time-to-hire, review-completion, payroll accuracy, survey response?). Benefits realisation — checking weeks later whether the promised value actually appeared — is the step almost everyone skips and the one that closes the loop.

Have teams draft a one-page go-live readiness checklist and a short success-measurement plan for their field — the success criteria, the adoption metric, and the outcome metric they would report back to the sponsor.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 21 · Testing, Go-Live & Measuring Success

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

Testing types — Functional, end-to-end and user-acceptance testing.

In plain words: Check each feature works, then whole processes work, then real users accept it.

Example: *Testing the offer letter generates correctly, then the full hire flow, then a recruiter signs off.*

Go-live readiness check — A pre-launch checklist confirming it is safe to switch on.

In plain words: A final honest go/no-go: data, UAT, training, support and a rollback plan all ready.

Example: *'Data reconciled? UAT signed off? Support staffed? Rollback ready?' — all yes before launch.*

Benefits realisation — Checking later whether the promised value actually appeared.

In plain words: Going back weeks after launch to see if the benefits you sold actually happened.

Example: *Confirming time-to-hire really fell by the target after the ATS went live.*

Adoption vs outcome metrics — Whether it's used vs whether it improved results.

In plain words: Usage shows people adopted it; outcomes show it actually made things better.

Example: *High logins (adoption) but unchanged time-to-hire (outcome) means dig deeper.*

FRAMEWORK

Land it safely: Test (functional → end-to-end → UAT) → readiness check → controlled cutover → hypercare → measure success against the original criteria (adoption + outcomes).

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Write a one-page go-live readiness checklist for your field's tool.
2. Define your success criteria and pick one adoption metric and one outcome metric to report.
3. Sketch a simple rollback plan: what you would do if go-live went badly wrong.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. Why is 'we went live on time and on budget' an incomplete definition of success?
2. Why do organisations so rarely check benefits realisation, and what does skipping it cost them?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- Josh Bersin, notes on HR technology benefits realisation (joshbersin.com).
- Vendor go-live / hypercare playbooks as practitioner references.

Hour 22 ★ Demo Day 2 — End-to-End Implementation Walkthrough

AT A GLANCE *5 min set-up · 40 min team walkthroughs & Q&A · 15 min peer scoring & feedback*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Demonstrate a configured tool running your field's core process on dummy data.
- Tell the implementation story: config, data, adoption, success measures.
- Evaluate peers' implementations against real-world criteria.

FACILITATION NOTES

The second milestone demo: teams show their tool actually working, not slides about it. Each team walks the panel through their configured tool running their field's core workflow on dummy data, and tells the implementation story around it — what they configured and why, how they handled data migration and quality, their adoption plan, and how they would measure success. This is where the abstract lifecycle becomes concrete.

As evaluator, push for live demonstration over description, and for honesty about what didn't work — a team that hit a limitation and adapted has learned more than one that claims everything was perfect. Keep walkthroughs tight and protect time for questions and peer scoring, which sharpen everyone's eye for what a good implementation looks like.

DEMO BRIEF

Hour 22 · Demo Day 2 — End-to-End Implementation Walkthrough

Walk the panel through your working implementation. Show the tool running your field's core process on dummy data, and tell the story of how you stood it up and how you'd make it succeed in a real organisation.

STEPS

1. Recap the field, the chosen tool, and the core process you implemented (one line).
2. Demonstrate the workflow live on dummy data, from start to finish.
3. Explain key configuration choices and how you handled data migration and quality.
4. Present your adoption plan and your success-measurement plan (criteria, adoption metric, outcome metric).
5. Share one thing that didn't work or a tool limitation you hit, and how you adapted.
6. Take panel questions and capture feedback.

DELIVERABLE

A live (or recorded) end-to-end demonstration plus a short implementation report: configuration log, migration notes, adoption plan, and success measures. Peers submit scorecards.

TIPS

- Show, don't tell — a live run of the workflow beats any number of slides.
- Be honest about limitations; evaluators reward learning over polish.
- Keep the dummy data clean enough to demo smoothly but realistic enough to be convincing.

EVALUATOR FOCUS

Does the tool actually work end to end on dummy data? Are configuration, migration and adoption handled thoughtfully? Is success defined against real criteria? Did the team learn from what went wrong?

Module 5 · Building AI-Based HR Tools

Move from selecting tools to building one — design and prototype an AI HR tool with no-code and AI.

Hour 23 Buy vs Build & the AI Prototyping Toolkit

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 25 min teaching · 15 min hands-on · 10 min thinking*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Decide when an organisation should buy a tool versus build its own.
- Survey the no-code and AI prototyping toolkit available in 2026.
- Choose a build approach for your capstone prototype.

TEACHING NOTES

Module 5 turns students from tool selectors into tool builders. Start with the strategic question every HR-tech decision faces: buy or build? Buying a SaaS tool is usually right when the need is common and well-served by the market (payroll, core HRMS); building makes sense when the need is unusual, specific to the organisation, or when no tool fits and the gap matters. A third, increasingly common answer is 'build a light tool on top of bought ones' — a small custom app or automation that fills a gap between systems. The point is to choose deliberately, not by default.

Then introduce the modern, accessible reality: thanks to no-code platforms and AI, a manager can now prototype a working HR tool without being a software engineer. Lay out the toolkit by category. Visual no-code builders (e.g., Bubble, Glide, Softr, Adalo) let you assemble apps by dragging components. AI app builders (e.g., Lovable, Bolt.new, v0, Replit's agent, Base44) generate a working app from a plain-language description. Automation tools (e.g., Zapier, Make) connect steps and systems without code. A data layer (e.g., Airtable or Google Sheets) stores the records. And LLM assistants (e.g., Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini) provide the 'AI brain' — summarising, drafting, classifying — via simple prompts or an integration.

Clarify the key distinction for students choosing an approach: visual no-code tools mean you assemble the app yourself by configuring components, while AI app builders mean you describe what you want and the AI generates it. Both are valid; many capstones will combine them — for example, a Glide or Airtable front end with an AI step that summarises candidate notes. Note the practical points: most of these tools have free tiers suitable for a student prototype, and none require students to write production code.

End by having each team make a buy-vs-build call for a realistic scenario in their field, and provisionally choose the toolkit they will use for their capstone prototype — a decision they will refine when they design the tool next session.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 23 · Buy vs Build & the AI Prototyping Toolkit

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

Buy vs build — Adopting a market tool vs creating your own.

In plain words: Buy when the market serves the need well; build when the need is unusual or unmet.

Example: Buy payroll software; build a small custom tool for a niche internal process.

Visual no-code vs AI app builder — Assembling an app yourself vs describing it and letting AI generate it.

In plain words: No-code: you drag the pieces together. AI builder: you say what you want and it builds it.
Example: *Glide (you assemble) vs Lovable/Bolt (you describe, it generates).*

Automation layer — Tools that connect steps and systems without code.
In plain words: Glue that makes one thing trigger another across apps automatically.
Example: *Zapier sending a Slack alert when a new candidate is added to a sheet.*

LLM as the AI brain — A large language model that summarises, drafts or classifies on request.
In plain words: The AI engine you call to read, write or sort text inside your tool.
Example: *Calling Claude to summarise five interview notes into a shortlist rationale.*

FRAMEWORK

The 2026 prototyping stack: Data layer (Airtable/Sheets) + Front end (visual no-code or AI app builder) + Automation (Zapier/Make) + AI brain (an LLM). Pick the lightest combination that delivers your field's core value.

THE AI / NO-CODE PROTOTYPING TOOLKIT (ILLUSTRATIVE, 2026)

Category	Example tools	Best for
AI app builders	Lovable, Bolt.new, v0, Replit agent, Base44	Generating a working app from a description
Visual no-code	Bubble, Glide, Softr, Adalo, Retool	Assembling an app by configuring components
Automation	Zapier, Make	Connecting steps and systems without code
Data layer	Airtable, Google Sheets	Storing and structuring the records
AI brain (LLM)	Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini	Summarising, drafting, classifying text

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Make a buy-vs-build decision for a realistic need in your field, with one line of justification.
2. Try one AI app builder and one visual no-code tool on a tiny task; note which suits your team.
3. Provisionally choose your capstone toolkit (data + front end + AI brain) and say why.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. When does building your own tool become a liability rather than an asset for an HR team?
2. If AI can generate an app from a description, what does the human still need to get right?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- Documentation/overviews for one AI app builder (e.g., Lovable or Bolt) and one no-code tool (e.g., Glide).
- Josh Bersin, perspectives on AI in HR technology (joshbersin.com).

Hour 24 Designing Your AI HR Tool

AT A GLANCE *10 min framing · 20 min teaching · 20 min canvas work*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Design an AI HR tool before building it, using a structured canvas.
- Decide where AI should assist versus automate, and design guardrails.
- Define the dummy data and success criteria for your prototype.

TEACHING NOTES

Good prototypes are designed before they are built. Introduce the AI Prototype Design Canvas as the planning tool for the capstone: a one-page structure that forces teams to think through problem, user, AI role, data, workflow, success and safety before touching a builder. Time spent here prevents the most common capstone failure — a clever-looking tool that solves no real problem.

Spend the most time on the assist-versus-automate decision, the heart of responsible AI design. For each step where AI is involved, decide whether it assists a human (suggests, drafts, summarises — a person decides) or automates (acts on its own). In HR, high-stakes judgements about people — hiring, ratings, pay — should keep a human firmly in the loop; AI is best aimed at the heavy lifting around those judgements (summarising, drafting, organising). Designing this deliberately is what separates a thoughtful tool from a reckless one.

Walk through the canvas sections so teams can fill it in: the problem and user; the job to be done; the AI's role (assist vs automate) at each step; the inputs and the dummy data needed; the core workflow; what the AI specifically does (the prompt or logic); the success criteria; and the responsible-AI guardrails (privacy, bias, transparency, human oversight). Each section is a question the team must answer before building.

The session is mostly working time: each team completes the canvas for their chosen field's prototype, with the evaluator reviewing and challenging. A signed-off canvas is the entry ticket to the two prototyping studios that follow.

STUDENT HANDOUT

Hour 24 · Designing Your AI HR Tool

KEY CONCEPTS — EXPLAINED SIMPLY, WITH EXAMPLES

AI Prototype Design Canvas — A one-page plan covering problem, user, AI role, data, workflow, success and safety.

In plain words: A design checklist you complete before building, so you build the right thing.

Example: Filling every box before opening a builder, so the team shares one clear plan.

Assist vs automate — AI suggests for a human to decide, vs AI acts on its own.

In plain words: Decide, step by step, where AI helps a person and where it's allowed to act alone.

Example: AI drafts the shortlist rationale (assist); a recruiter still makes the call (not automate).

Dummy data design — The fake but realistic records the prototype runs on.

In plain words: The made-up data your tool needs to demonstrate its value.

Example: *Twenty fictional candidates with notes, for an AI screening assistant to summarise.*

Guardrails — Built-in limits for privacy, bias, transparency and oversight.

In plain words: The safety rails that keep an AI tool from causing harm.

Example: *Showing the AI's reasoning and requiring a human to approve any decision.*

FRAMEWORK

The AI Prototype Design Canvas (complete before building): Problem & user → Job-to-be-done → AI role (assist/automate) → Inputs & dummy data → Core workflow → What the AI does (prompt/logic) → Success criteria → Responsible-AI guardrails.

AI PROTOTYPE DESIGN CANVAS — SECTIONS & GUIDING QUESTIONS

Canvas section	Question to answer
Problem & user	What HR problem, for whom, and why does it matter?
Job-to-be-done	What does the user need to get done?
AI role	At each step, does AI assist a human or automate? Where must a human decide?
Inputs & dummy data	What data does it use? What dummy data will you create?
Core workflow	What are the steps from input to useful output?
What the AI does	What exactly does the AI do (summarise/draft/classify)? Outline the prompt or logic.
Success criteria	How will you know the prototype works and adds value?
Guardrails	Privacy, bias, transparency, human oversight — what protects people?

PRACTICAL WORK

1. Complete the AI Prototype Design Canvas for your field's capstone prototype.
2. For every AI step, explicitly mark it 'assist' or 'automate' and justify any automation.
3. Specify the dummy data you'll need and draft the core AI prompt or logic in plain language.

THINK ABOUT IT

1. In your field, which decision must never be fully automated, and why?
2. How could a well-meaning AI HR tool cause harm if its guardrails were skipped?

RECOMMENDED READINGS

- Miranda Bogen, "All the Ways Hiring Algorithms Can Introduce Bias," Harvard Business Review (2019).
- Practitioner guides on prompt design for business tools (LLM provider documentation).

Hour 25 ★ Studio — Prototyping I: Build the Core

AT A GLANCE *10 min set-up · 40 min hands-on build · 10 min mentor check-ins*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Build the core of your AI HR tool — data, interface and main workflow.
- Get a working (non-AI) version running on dummy data.
- Test the core flow and prepare to add the AI layer.

FACILITATION NOTES

The first build studio. Working from their signed-off canvas, teams build the core of their tool — the data layer, a simple interface, and the main workflow — on the toolkit they chose, before adding any AI. Getting a plain, working version running first is deliberate: it ensures the tool does its basic job and gives the AI layer something real to plug into next session.

Mentor actively: the common traps are over-scoping (trying to build everything) and gold-plating the interface before the workflow works. Steer teams to a thin, working slice that takes real dummy data through the core workflow to a useful output. Teams that get the core running today will have a calm, productive Prototyping II; teams that don't will be rushing.

STUDIO BRIEF

Hour 25 · Studio — Prototyping I: Build the Core

Build the working core of your prototype — without AI yet. By the end you should be able to take dummy data through your tool's main workflow to a useful output.

STEPS

1. Set up the data layer with your dummy data (e.g., in Airtable or Sheets).
2. Build a simple interface and the main workflow from input to output.
3. Run real dummy data through the core flow and confirm it works.
4. Note where the AI layer will plug in next session (the step you marked 'assist' on your canvas).
5. List what's still rough so you can prioritise in Prototyping II.

DELIVERABLE

A working, AI-free core of your tool that takes dummy data through the main workflow, plus a note of where AI will be added.

TIPS

- Build the thinnest slice that works end to end; resist adding extra features.
- Don't polish the interface until the workflow actually works.
- Keep your canvas open — build what you designed, and flag if the design needs to change.

EVALUATOR FOCUS

Is there a genuinely working core (data → workflow → output) on dummy data? Did the team stay scoped to their canvas? Is the AI insertion point clear?

Hour 26 ★ Studio — Prototyping II: Add the AI Layer

AT A GLANCE *10 min set-up · 40 min hands-on build · 10 min mentor check-ins*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Add the AI capability to your prototype and test it on dummy data.
- Implement your guardrails and human-in-the-loop checkpoints.
- Prepare a compelling demo narrative for the capstone.

FACILITATION NOTES

The second build studio completes the prototype. Teams add the AI layer designed on their canvas — typically an LLM step that summarises, drafts, classifies or recommends — to the working core they built last session, then test it on dummy data and refine the prompt or logic until the output is genuinely useful. This is where the tool earns its 'AI' label.

Insist that teams implement their guardrails, not just the capability: the human-in-the-loop checkpoint where a person reviews or approves, transparency so users can see what the AI did, and care with the dummy (never real) personal data. Then have them shape the demo narrative — the problem, the before/after, and a live run — because a brilliant prototype poorly demonstrated wins nothing on capstone day. Mentor on both the build and the story.

STUDIO BRIEF

Hour 26 · Studio — Prototyping II: Add the AI Layer

Add and test the AI layer, wire in your guardrails, and turn the working prototype into a demo you can tell a story with. By the end you should have an AI-enabled tool running on dummy data and a clear demo plan.

STEPS

1. Add the AI step (e.g., an LLM call) at the point you marked on your canvas; connect it to your core flow.
2. Test on dummy data and refine the prompt or logic until the output is genuinely useful.
3. Implement guardrails: a human-in-the-loop checkpoint, visible AI reasoning, and dummy-data-only handling.
4. Run the full tool end to end and fix the rough edges from Prototyping I.
5. Draft your demo narrative: the problem, the before/after, and the live run you'll show.
6. Do a quick timed run-through with your team.

DELIVERABLE

A working AI-enabled prototype on dummy data, with guardrails in place, plus a drafted demo narrative for the capstone.

TIPS

- Refining the prompt is real work — budget time to iterate until the AI output is actually good.
- Make the human-in-the-loop checkpoint visible in the demo; it shows responsible design.

- Rehearse the live run once today — demos fail on the parts no one tested live.

EVALUATOR FOCUS

Does the AI layer add real value (not AI for its own sake)? Are guardrails and human oversight genuinely implemented? Is there a clear, rehearsed demo narrative?

Hour 27 ★ Responsible AI, Privacy & Tool Evaluation (Mentor Clinic)

AT A GLANCE *15 min teaching · 30 min cross-team clinic · 15 min fixes & planning*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Apply responsible-AI and privacy principles to your own prototype.
- Stress-test another team's tool against a responsible-AI checklist.
- Identify and fix the biggest responsible-use gap before the capstone.

FACILITATION NOTES

Before the capstone, every prototype gets a responsible-use check — applied to the actual tool each team has built, not taught as theory. The principles themselves (data ethics, privacy, algorithmic bias and AI governance in HR) are developed conceptually in the New Age HR course; here they become a hands-on checklist run against working prototypes. Open with only a brief, practical reminder of what the checklist tests: that people data is sensitive and employees cannot easily opt out; that a tool should have a clear purpose and use only the data it needs (and only dummy data here); that it should be transparent about what the AI did; that it should be checked for bias via proxies; that a human must stay in the loop on consequential outputs; and that India's DPDP Act, the EU's GDPR and the EU AI Act's high-risk treatment of HR uses make these legal as well as ethical expectations. Reinforce the one-line message: 'we can build it' is not 'we should ship it'.

Spend the session in the clinic, not the lecture. Teams pair up and stress-test each other's prototypes against the responsible-AI checklist, acting as a critical-but-helpful review board — probing where the AI could be unfair, where privacy is at risk, whether a human is genuinely in the loop, and whether the tool is transparent about what it does. The reviewing team writes up the biggest gaps; the owning team leaves with a prioritised fix list. As mentor, push both honesty in the critique and constructiveness in the response, and make sure every team makes at least one real fix to its own tool before capstone day.

MENTOR CLINIC

Hour 27 · Responsible AI, Privacy & Tool Evaluation (Mentor Clinic)

Run a responsible-AI review of your own and another team's prototype. The goal is to catch fairness, privacy, transparency and oversight gaps now — while there is still time to fix them.

RESPONSIBLE-AI CHECKLIST FOR HR PROTOTYPES

Principle	Question to pass
Purpose & minimisation	Clear purpose? Using only the data it needs (and only dummy data)?
Transparency	Can users see what the AI did and why?
Fairness / bias	Could it disadvantage a group? How would you check?
Human oversight	Does a human review or approve any consequential output?
Privacy & security	Is sensitive data protected; no real personal data used?

Principle	Question to pass
Accountability	Is it clear who is responsible if it gets something wrong?

STEPS

1. Self-assess your prototype against the responsible-AI checklist below; note where it falls short.
2. Pair with another team and review their prototype against the same checklist as a critical-but-helpful board.
3. For each tool, agree the single biggest responsible-use gap and a concrete fix.
4. Make the highest-priority fix to your own tool now, with mentor support.
5. Write a short ‘responsible-use note’ you could show users of your tool.

DELIVERABLE

A completed responsible-AI checklist for your tool, a peer review of another team’s tool, and at least one implemented fix plus a short responsible-use note.

TIPS

- Be specific in critique — ‘the AI rejects candidates with no human review’ beats ‘it might be biased’.
- Treat the review as a gift; fixing a gap now is far cheaper than defending it on capstone day.
- Transparency is often the easiest high-value fix: show what the AI did and why.

EVALUATOR FOCUS

Did the team honestly find real gaps (not trivial ones)? Is the human-in-the-loop genuine? Did they actually fix the top issue, and can they explain their tool’s responsible-use stance?

Module 6 · Capstone: Demos & Synthesis

Demonstrate what you built, defend it, and make sense of the whole journey.

Hour 28 ★ Capstone Build & Dress Rehearsal (Mentor Clinic)

AT A GLANCE *10 min set-up · 35 min build & rehearse · 15 min mentor feedback*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Finalise your capstone prototype and demo.
- Rehearse the demo and tighten the narrative under time pressure.
- Act on mentor feedback before demo day.

FACILITATION NOTES

The final working session before the capstone demos. Teams finalise their prototypes, fix the responsible-use issues raised in the clinic, and rehearse their demo end to end against the clock. The emphasis shifts from building to communicating: a strong prototype with a weak demo under-sells the work, so this session is as much about the story and the live run as the code.

Run it as a mentor clinic: each team does a timed dress rehearsal in front of the evaluator (and ideally another team), then gets specific feedback on both the tool and the telling — leading with the problem, showing a clean live run, making the AI value and the human-in-the-loop visible, and handling likely questions. Teams leave with a short, prioritised fix list for the final polish.

MENTOR CLINIC

Hour 28 · Capstone Build & Dress Rehearsal (Mentor Clinic)

Finalise and rehearse. Deliver a full, timed dress rehearsal of your capstone demo, get feedback, and lock down the last fixes. Treat this as the demo before the demo.

STEPS

1. Apply the responsible-use fixes from the previous clinic and confirm the tool runs cleanly end to end.
2. Do a full, timed dress rehearsal of your demo in front of the mentor (and another team if possible).
3. Get feedback on the tool and the narrative; note the top three improvements.
4. Make the highest-priority fixes; prepare a fallback (e.g., screenshots or a recording) in case the live demo fails.
5. Confirm roles: who presents what, and who drives the live demo.

DELIVERABLE

A finalised prototype and a rehearsed, timed capstone demo, with a fallback plan and a clear division of presenting roles.

TIPS

- Time yourselves honestly — over-running is the most common demo-day failure.
- Prepare a fallback (recording/screenshots); never let a live-demo glitch sink your story.
- Lead with the problem and the value, not a tour of the build.

EVALUATOR FOCUS

> *Is the prototype final and stable? Is the demo rehearsed, on time, and led by the problem? Did the team act on earlier feedback and prepare a fallback?*

Hour 29 ★ Capstone Demo Day I

AT A GLANCE *5 min set-up · 45 min capstone demos & Q&A · 10 min panel & peer scoring*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Present a working AI HR prototype to a panel as a capstone.
- Defend design choices, including responsible-use decisions.
- Evaluate peers' capstones against a shared scorecard.

FACILITATION NOTES

The capstone payoff begins. Roughly half the teams present their AI HR prototypes to a panel — the course evaluator and, ideally, a guest practitioner — with the rest presenting in Session 30. Each team delivers the full story: the problem in their chosen field, the tool they built, a live run on dummy data, the AI value, the responsible-use guardrails, and what they'd do next. Run it like a real product pitch to leadership.

Use a shared scorecard so the panel and peers assess every capstone on the same criteria — problem and need, the working prototype, sensible use of AI, responsible design, and the quality of the demo and answers. Hold teams to leading with the problem, showing a live run, and being honest about limits. Capture scores and feedback for the synthesis in the final session.

DEMO BRIEF

Hour 29 · Capstone Demo Day I

Present your capstone: a working AI HR prototype that solves a real problem in your chosen field, built and demonstrated on dummy data. Pitch it to the panel as you would to a leadership team deciding whether to back it.

CAPSTONE DEMO SCORECARD (ILLUSTRATIVE)

Criterion	What strong looks like
Problem & need	A real, well-understood problem in the field
Working prototype	Runs end to end on dummy data, live
Use of AI	AI adds genuine value where it fits; not gratuitous
Responsible design	Real guardrails, human-in-the-loop, transparency
Demo & defence	Clear story, on time, honest, handles questions

STEPS

1. Open with the problem and who has it (lead with the need, not the build).
2. Show the prototype live on dummy data, end to end.
3. Explain where AI assists vs decides, and show the human-in-the-loop and transparency.
4. Summarise your responsible-use stance and one honest limitation.
5. Close with the value and what you'd build or pilot next; take panel questions.

DELIVERABLE

A live capstone demo (with fallback recording) and a short capstone write-up: the design canvas, the prototype, responsible-use note, and next steps. Peers submit scorecards.

TIPS

- Lead with the problem and the before/after — the panel must feel why this matters.
- Show, don't describe; a clean live run is the whole point of a demo.
- Own your limitations — a thoughtful 'what we'd fix next' builds credibility.

EVALUATOR FOCUS

Does the prototype solve a real need and work on dummy data? Is AI used where it genuinely helps, with real guardrails? Is the demo clear and the team's reasoning sound under questioning?

Hour 30 ★ Capstone Demo Day II & Course Synthesis

AT A GLANCE *35 min remaining capstone demos & scoring · 15 min synthesis · 10 min reflection*

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Present the remaining capstones and complete peer evaluation.
- Draw out the through-lines of the whole course.
- Build a personal roadmap for working with HR tools and AI.

FACILITATION NOTES

The remaining teams present their capstones to the panel under the same scorecard, completing the course's third and largest milestone. Keep the energy and rigour of Demo Day I, and ensure every team gets substantive feedback. Once demos finish, shift from presenting to making sense of the whole journey.

Lead a synthesis of the course's through-lines: that selecting a tool starts from needs, not features; that implementation succeeds or fails on data, change and adoption, not technology; that building is now within reach of any manager through no-code and AI; and that with people data, responsible design is not optional. Tie the arc together — students went from researching the market, to gathering needs, to selecting, to implementing on dummy data, to building their own AI tool — the full life of an HR-tech decision.

Close with reflection and a forward look. Each student notes what they can now do that they couldn't before, which part of the cycle (research, needs, selection, implementation, building, responsible use) is their strength and which to develop, and one way they will use these skills in their HR career. Point them toward continued learning — deeper no-code/AI building, and following the fast-moving HR-tech and AI landscape — and remind them that tools will keep changing, but the disciplines they practised will not.

DEMO BRIEF

Hour 30 · Capstone Demo Day II & Course Synthesis

Present (if you haven't yet), then step back. After the final demos, we synthesise the whole course and you set your personal roadmap for working with HR tools and AI.

STEPS

1. Remaining teams deliver their capstone demos under the shared scorecard; peers score.
2. Contribute to the synthesis: name the through-lines that connect research, needs, selection, implementation and building.
3. Reflect: what can you now do that you couldn't at the start of the course?
4. Identify your strongest and weakest part of the HR-tech cycle and one way to develop the weak one.
5. Write one concrete way you'll use these skills in your HR career, and your stance on responsible AI in HR.

DELIVERABLE

Final capstone demos and scores, plus each student's short personal roadmap: strengths, a development goal, a career application, and a responsible-AI stance.

TIPS

- Listen actively to other fields' capstones — the patterns repeat across recruitment, payroll, engagement and the rest.
- Be specific in your roadmap; 'learn more AI' is weaker than 'build one no-code tool a quarter'.
- Remember the disciplines outlast the tools — vendors and features will change; needs-first thinking won't.

EVALUATOR FOCUS

Across the cohort: can students research, select, implement and build responsibly? Do their reflections show they grasp the through-lines rather than just the individual tools?

Course Toolkit — Templates & Rubrics

These templates are yours to copy and reuse across the studios, demos and capstone — adapt them to your chosen field.

1 · Needs & Requirements Template

Use during Module 2 to capture what the organisation actually needs. Prioritise with MoSCoW (Must / Should / Could / Won't) and attach a measurable success criterion to each requirement.

ID	Requirement / need	Priority	Success criterion
R1	(e.g.) Recruiters can track a candidate from apply to offer	Must	100% of openings tracked in the tool
R2	(e.g.) Managers approve requisitions on mobile	Should	Approval time under 24 hours
R3	(...)	Could	(...)
R4	(...)	Won't (now)	(...)

2 · Weighted Scoring Matrix Template

Use in Module 3 to compare shortlisted tools objectively. Set weights that sum to 100%, score each tool 1–5 against each criterion, and let weight × score decide — not the flashiest demo.

Criterion (weight %)	Tool A (1–5)	Tool B (1–5)	Tool C (1–5)
Fit to must-have needs (30%)			
Ease of use / adoption (20%)			
Total cost of ownership (20%)			
Security & India compliance (15%)			
Integration & scalability (15%)			
Weighted total (100%)			

3 • Implementation Plan Template

Use in Module 4 to plan and track your end-to-end rollout. Give every phase an owner, a target date and a status, and note the top risk.

Phase	Owner	Target date	Status / top risk
Plan & mobilise			
Configure			
Migrate data			
Integrate			
Test / UAT			
Train			
Go-live & hypercare			

4 · AI Prototype Design Canvas

Complete this in Module 5 before building anything. A signed-off canvas is the entry ticket to the prototyping studios.

Canvas section	Your answer
Problem & user	
Job-to-be-done	
AI role (assist / automate per step)	
Inputs & dummy data	
Core workflow	
What the AI does (prompt / logic)	
Success criteria	
Responsible-AI guardrails	

5 · Demo & Capstone Scorecard

Used by the evaluator panel and peers at each demo milestone. Score each criterion, note one strength and one improvement.

Criterion	Score (1–5)	Strength / improvement
Problem & need (fit to gathered needs)		
Substance (research / implementation / prototype)		
Use of AI & responsible design (capstone)		
Evidence & honesty (incl. limitations)		
Demo clarity & response to questions		

Assessment & Evaluation

A practical, demo-led model — students are assessed almost entirely on what they research, implement and build, with the AI-prototype capstone as the major summative piece.

Components & Weighting

This is a studio course, so there is no conventional written examination. Students are evaluated continuously on their deliverables — the requirements they gather, the recommendation and implementation they demo, and the AI tool they build — plus their participation as builders and as peer-evaluators. The AI-prototype capstone is the major summative assessment.

The split below is continuous and deliverable-based; where the institute requires a CIE/SEE division, the capstone (Demo & write-up) maps naturally to the semester-end evaluation and the remaining 70 to internal evaluation. Weightings can be tuned to prevailing ordinances.

MARKS DISTRIBUTION (OUT OF 100)

Component	Mode	Marks	Outcomes
Requirements document (needs gathering, M2)	Continuous	10	CO2
Demo 1 — tool research & recommendation (M3)	Continuous	15	CO1, CO3
Demo 2 — end-to-end implementation (M4)	Continuous	20	CO4
Studio participation & peer evaluation	Continuous	15	CO1–CO6
Individual reflection / personal roadmap	Continuous	10	CO1, CO6
Capstone — AI prototype demo & write-up (M6)	Summative	30	CO5, CO6
Total		100	

Continuous internal work = 70 marks · Capstone (summative) = 30 marks. Almost the entire grade rewards doing the work of an HR-tech professional — researching, selecting, implementing and building — not recalling it.

Milestone Rubrics

DEMO 1 — TOOL RESEARCH & RECOMMENDATION · 15 MARKS

Criterion	Marks	Strong work
Quality & currency of market research	4	Real, current tools; verified features
Recommendation traced to needs & scoring	5	Choice follows from weighted criteria
Cost, risk & honest weakness covered	3	TCO, security, a real downside
Clarity of the readout & answers	3	Leads with the decision; defends it

DEMO 2 — END-TO-END IMPLEMENTATION · 20 MARKS

Criterion	Marks	Strong work
Working configuration on dummy data	6	Core workflow runs end to end, live
Data migration & quality handling	4	Mapped, cleaned, reconciled
Change & adoption plan	4	Stakeholders, training, adoption metric
Success measures defined	3	Adoption + outcome metrics vs criteria
Demo clarity & learning from issues	3	Honest, clear, adapted to problems

CAPSTONE — AI PROTOTYPE · 30 MARKS

Criterion	Marks	Strong work
Problem & need in the chosen field	4	Real, well-understood problem
Working prototype on dummy data	8	Runs end to end; AI value is real
Sound design (canvas, assist vs automate)	5	Deliberate, documented design
Responsible AI (guardrails, human-in-loop)	6	Genuine privacy, fairness, oversight
Demo, write-up & defence	7	Clear story; honest; handles questions

INDICATIVE TEN-POINT GRADING SCALE

Marks (%)	Grade	Grade point	Descriptor
90–100	O (Outstanding)	10	Exceptional, professional-grade work
80–89	A+ (Excellent)	9	Strong across the full cycle
70–79	A (Very good)	8	Solid; minor gaps
60–69	B+ (Good)	7	Competent; some inconsistency
55–59	B (Above average)	6	Adequate grasp
50–54	C (Average)	5	Meets minimum
40–49	P (Pass)	4	Marginal
Below 40	F (Fail)	0	Does not meet requirements

Minimum passing follows prevailing institute and Goa University norms, including any minimum on the capstone. Attendance and eligibility follow prevailing regulations.

COURSE LEARNING OUTCOMES (COS)

CO1 — Explain the HR tech stack, SaaS and AI, and the major HR tool categories and fields.

CO2 — Gather an organisation's needs and write clear requirements and success criteria.

CO3 — Research, evaluate and select HR tools against needs using structured criteria.

CO4 — Implement a tool end-to-end on dummy data — configure, migrate, manage change and go live.

CO5 — Design and build an AI-based HR tool prototype using no-code and AI.

CO6 — Apply responsible-AI, privacy and evaluation principles to HR tools.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY & AI-USE NOTE

This course actively teaches the use of AI and no-code tools, in keeping with the AI² spirit of the programme. Students are expected to use such tools for their prototypes and must disclose what they used and how. All work must be the team's own design and judgement, all data must be dummy data (never real personal data), and the reasoning behind decisions must be the students' own. Plagiarism and undisclosed reuse are handled under the institute's academic-integrity policy.